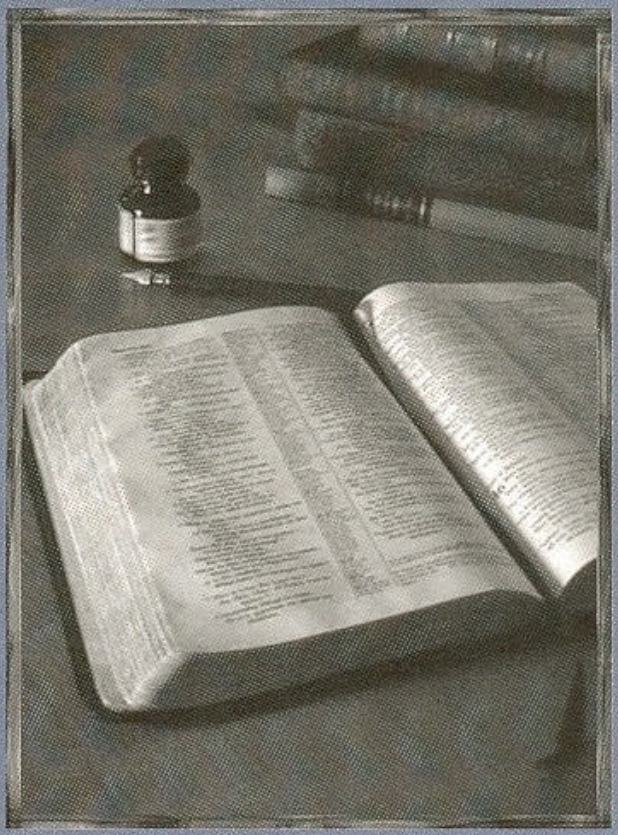
The Power of God unto Salvation



Is the Gospel Enough?

Joel Finck

The Power of God Unto Salvation

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By Joel Finck

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THE POWER OF GOD UNTO SALVATION
Is The Gospel Enough?

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DEDICATION

To my Dad,

Mr. Calvin Finck

His first name notwithstanding, Dad is NOT a Calvinist. He happens to believe that ANYONE can be saved, if they but believe on the Lord Jesus Christ. "Whosoever will may come !"

Thanks, Dad, for raising your children in the nurture and admonition of the Lord, and for setting the example by faithfully sharing Christ with the lonely, the down and out, and the prisoners, when it seemed no one else cared.

With Special Thanks To My Proof-Readers:

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&
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TABLE OF CONTENTS

PART ONE:
THE FIVE POINTS OF CALVINISM

Introduction: What Is Calvinism? 5

Chapter One: 7
TOTAL DEPRAVITY

Chapter Two: 11
UNCONDITIONAL ELECTION

Chapter Three: 14
LIMITED ATONEMENT

Chapter Four: 15
IRRESISTIBLE GRACE

Chapter Five: 17
PERSEVERANCE OF THE SAINTS

PART TWO:
KEY WORDS RELATING TO CALVINISM

Chapter Six: 18
ELECTION

Chapter Seven: 31
PREDESTINATION

Chapter Eight: 34
FOREKNOWLEDGE

PART THREE:
ANSWERS TO CALVINIST “PROOF-TEXTS”

Chapter Nine: 38
ROMANS CHAPTER 9

Chapter Ten: 44
OTHER “PROOF-TEXTS”

Chapter Eleven: 53
PRACTICAL RAMIFICATIONS

PART ONE:
THE FIVE POINTS OF CALVINISM

Introduction:

What is Calvinism?

Does it really matter whether or not we preach the gospel? Will not God save those whom He has chosen to save whether we do anything about it or not? After all, is not God sovereign? God is in control of the universe. How could the actions of men affect the outcome of who is saved and who is not? And besides, does not God already know who will be saved and who will not, therefore, it is as good as done, right? There is nothing we can do to change it.

Have you ever heard these arguments before? Have you ever thought them? Perhaps you have even used them from time to time. These arguments illustrate some of the basic tenets of Calvinism and its view of election and predestination. What is Calvinism? We will begin with a short history lesson so that you understand what we are talking about.

Calvinism is a theological viewpoint based on the teachings of a great reformation leader named John Calvin. He lived in the 1500's, was born in France in 1509, but moved to Switzerland in 1536 where he ministered most of his life. He spent a short period of time in exile in Germany, but returned shortly thereafter to Switzerland. Originally, John Calvin was Catholic as were most of the people in Europe at that time. The Protestant reformation was just beginning at that period, so there was no other denomination besides the Roman Catholic Church. Over a period of time, John Calvin developed several doctrines that have been adopted by various denominations. Some of these will be explained later.

In particular, John Calvin is noted for his views on predestination and church government. He is probably most famous for his views on predestination, but he also developed a theology of church government which is known as a Presbyterian form of government. The Presbyterian denomination is based on this form of government, consisting of an elder system which is quite scriptural. Unfortunately, he expanded it to the point of forming a denominational hierarchy which was in charge of all the local churches. This is where he broke from Scripture, for God desires each local church to be answerable to Himself, not to a human hierarchy.

Calvin's views on predestination are generally condensed into five points, the first letter of each spelling out the word, "T.U.L.I.P." The "T" in T.U.L.I.P. stands for - Total depravity or total inability, "U" Unconditional election, "L" Limited atonement, 'T' Irresistible grace, and "P" Perseverance of the saints. Actually, these five points were developed after John Calvin's death through an interesting set of circumstances.

John Calvin developed many followers in the course of his life. One of his followers was named Jacobus Arminius. Jacobus Arminius was contemporary with John Calvin for only four years. In other words, he was four years old when John Calvin died; therefore, he was actually schooled in his theology by Calvin's successor, Theodore Beza. Since Jacobus Arminius was originally taught under Calvinistic influence, he basically accepted the teachings of Calvinism but later rejected several points. He subsequently gained a following of his own who became known as "Arminians." Calvinism and Arminianism thus formed two theological approaches to predestination.

Arminius, of course, died, and his followers published his viewpoints in a document known as the "Remonstrance." This document established five points of Arminian doctrine. Those who were teaching Calvinist doctrine recognized that these five Arminian points were almost exactly the opposite of what Calvin had taught. The Calvinists responded to the five Arminian points with the five points of Calvinism. These were developed into a "Counter Remonstrance" at the Council of Dort, Dortrecht, Holland in 1618-19. These five points are the familiar "TULIP" points which we will be considering in this study. We might truly say that the "TULIP" doctrine came from the land of tulips. While this is interesting, we must say that it is entirely without any spiritual significance!

We will begin by outlining the contrasts between Arminianism and Calvinism, in general. First of all, Arminianism says that man has a choice whether or not to believe, whereas Calvinism teaches only those whom God chooses can believe.

The second difference is, Arminianism teaches that foreknowledge is informative. This simply means, according to Arminian doctrine, that God looks ahead through time, sees who will believe, and then picks those people to be saved. Calvinism on the other hand, teaches that foreknowledge is determinative rather than informative. In other words, God knows in advance those to whom He will give faith. To the Calvinist, it is not a matter of looking ahead to see who will believe, but rather it is deciding in advance who will be given faith. This forms the basis by which God knows who will be saved, according to Calvinist doctrine.

A third difference, and a very major point, is that Arminianism teaches that salvation can be lost if a person stops believing. Calvinism teaches salvation cannot be lost, because according to Calvinist doctrine, it was God who caused the person to believe in the first place, and God just keeps causing him to believe; therefore, the saints remain saved because God gives them perseverance to keep believing.

The fourth difference is that Arminianism is the theology of the Methodist denomination.[1] Also, the Pentecostal, Charismatic and Mennonite groups today are basically Arminian in their doctrine, particularly in the area of loss of salvation. This is one of the major points of their doctrine. Calvinism is the theology of the Reformed and Presbyterian denominations.[2] Generally speaking, Calvinism also

[1] Reid, *Dictionary of Christianity in America,* p. 79.
[2] Reid, Op. cit., p. 212.

dominates in Baptist circles (except "Free Will Baptists") as well as many Fundamentalist circles.

The mistake which Christians almost always make when considering these two viewpoints is the belief that in order to be consistent, one must be totally Arminian or totally Calvinistic in his thinking. This study will show that this simply is not the case. There are some elements of Arminianism which can be supported by Scripture. There are other parts of Arminianism which are clearly false. The idea that salvation can be lost is not supported by the Word of God, "rightly divided" (II Tim. 2:15). Some elements of Calvinism are accurate, such as eternal security. This is an accurate doctrinal belief, although the reason that Calvinists believe it is inaccurate. They believe that salvation cannot be lost because God simply continues to give faith to the believer. Paul teaches that salvation cannot be lost because the believer is sealed by the Holy Spirit (Eph. 1:13; 4:30). If we rightly divide the Word of truth, we can sort through a lot of the errors whether they be on the side of Arminianism or the side of Calvinism. The fight division of Scripture holds the answers to many of the apparent contradictions that we find between these viewpoints.

Chapter One:

TOTAL DEPRAVITY

As we look at the five points of Calvinism we must say in all fairness that many Calvinists do not hold to all five of these points. Generally speaking, we designate how extreme a person is in their Calvinism by how many points they hold. When we speak of a "five-point Calvinist," we are referring to a Calvinist who holds the most extreme position on predestination. Generally speaking, Calvinists will be either "three-pointers" or "four-pointers." The point which even many Calvinists do not hold to is the one in the middle, Limited Atonement. Limited Atonement is the doctrine that Christ only died for those who would eventually be saved (or, as the Calvinist would say, "the elect"). All but the most ardent Calvinists have a hard time stating that Christ did not die for all people, especially in the light of passages like I Timothy 2:4,6; 4:10, I John 2:2 and II Peter 2:1. But, there are those who definitely hold to all five points. The author is sometimes asked how many points he holds, to which he responds, "I am a 'zero-point' Calvinist." That is, we believe there is merit to certain aspects of some of these points, but they must be defined according to Scripture, not according to traditional Calvinist teaching.

Let us look at the first point, Total Depravity. For each of these points, we will give quotations from various Calvinists, so as not to misrepresent them.

The traditional position, according to J. Oliver Buswell, says "the natural man in his fallen condition is totally unable in the slightest degree to contribute to or cooperate in his own regeneration."[3] While this may sound like a reasonable definition on the surface, what most Calvinists mean by this is that a man cannot even believe until

[3] Buswell, *A Systematic Theology of the Christian Religion*, p. 138.

he is regenerated. The standard Calvinistic doctrine on this point says that once God regenerates an individual, then they believe. Buswell quotes Hermann Witsius (a 17th century Covenant Theologian), "Regeneration is the hyperphysical act of God, by which the elect man, who is spiritually dead, is embued with new life, divine life, and that from the incorruptible seed of God's Word, fecundated by the transcendent power of the Spirit."[4] You will notice that Witsius' definition does not even mention faith as being a part of the regeneration process. Jerome Zanchius (a contemporary of Calvin) writes, "Now if repentance and faith are gifts...then these are not the fruits of man's free-will."[5]

Several Scriptures are used by Calvinists to show that man cannot even believe without first being regenerated. John 6:44 says, "No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him: and I will raise him up at the last day." This passage is often interpreted to mean that the only people who are saved are those whom the Father has drawn and that all others cannot be saved. What is the answer to this? Right here in John's gospel, we find another statement by Christ which clarifies the first. While it is certainly tree that no one would come to Christ except he were drawn, Christ states in John 12:32, "and I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me." God has intervened in the affairs of men to the extent that He has drawn all men to Himself (we will see how He has done this in a moment). This does not mean all men are saved. But it does mean that it is possible for all men to be saved, as we will show later.

A second Scripture which is often used to teach the Calvinist's perspective on total depravity is Romans 3:10,11, "As it is written, there is none righteous, no not one. There is none that understandeth, there is none that seeketh after God." The Calvinist would ask, "How could someone possibly believe before they are regenerated if no one understands and no one seeks after God?" This is a valid question, and the answer has already been given earlier in the Book of Romans. The text in Romans chapter 3 is, of course, absolutely tree: there is no man who seeks after God; it is not in man's essential makeup to do so. But in Romans chapter 1, Paul shows that God has already provided a remedy to this problem. Romans 1:18, 19 says, "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who hold the truth in unrighteousness; Because that which may be known of God is manifest in them; for God hath shewed it unto them." You see, if indeed man has no way of knowing anything about God and therefore does not seek God, could not man stand before God and argue that he should be excused for not seeking that which could not be known? Paul deals with that possibility by saying that God has done something to give enlightenment to mankind - something they could understand.

Actually, He has done two things according to Romans 1:19, the first is, "that which may be known of God is manifest in them...." Now, we must be very careful here. Liberal theologians have often taught that man is not really fallen. He may have a few problems, but basically, he is still pretty good, and that he even has a little "spark" of the divine (a phrase they will sometimes use). "All we have to do," they

[4] Buswell, Op. Cit, p. 169.
[5] Zanchius, Absolute Predestination, p. 59.

will say, "is just educate him and fan the spark into flame and then he will be all right." This is NOT what Paul is saying here! Paul clearly teaches that there is no good thing in man (that is, in his flesh - Rom. 7:18). But this does not change the fact that God has revealed something to every man to the extent that certain things about God are manifested in him (Rom. 1:19a). Now, in what part of man is there an awareness of God? Romans 2:15 explains, "Which shew the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness, and their thoughts the mean while accusing or else excusing one another." God in his mercy and grace has chosen to implant, even within fallen man, enough consciousness of the difference between good and evil so that he is without excuse. This is "manifest in them."

But also, it says in Romans 1:19, "for God hath shewed it unto them," whereas the conscience is within, that which God shows unto them is without, or outside. Paul explains this in verse 20, "for the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, even his eternal power and Godhead; so that they are without excuse." Again, man in and of himself would never seek God, as Paul states in Romans chapter 3. But God has revealed Himself through "creation" and "the things that are made" to give man enough knowledge that he can begin to respond to God in some way. This is what Paul means in Acts 17:26,27, "And hath made of one blood all nations of men for to dwell on all the face of the earth, and hath determined the times before appointed, and the bounds of their habitation; That they should seek the Lord, if haply they might feel after him, and find him, though he be not far from every one of us." As man responds, God can show him further light.

A third passage that is used to show that man cannot believe until he is regenerated is 1 Corinthians 2:14, "But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him: neither can he know them because they are spiritually discerned." Again, the Calvinist would ask, "How can man possibly believe the gospel, which is spiritual in nature, when it says the natural man cannot receive spiritual things?" This might look like a watertight case for the Calvinist except for two things, they have forgotten to look at the context and at the grammar.

What is Paul's point here? The first key is the context. Paul is explaining the revelation of Scripture, and in particular, the Mystery (I Cor. 2:7). In verse 9 he affirms that the things of God cannot be learned by human observation or reasoning, "But as it is written, Eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither have entered into the heart of man, the things which God hath prepared for them that love him" (I Cor. 2:9). So how can we know the things of God? Only through a divine revelation: "But God hath REVEALED them unto us by His Spirit" (vs. 10). Is this revelation made directly to every man? No! Paul is speaking here of divine revelation given directly to him as an apostle, as he says in verse 13, "Which things we speak."

The second key to this passage is the grammar. The word "natural" in verse 14 is literally "soulish." The point Paul makes in this text is that the Spirit of God revealed

His word to his (Paul's) human spirit (see vss. 11,12), not his soul (vs. 14). While the principle is certainly true that in the broadest sense, an unsaved man may be called a "natural" man, and as such might not be inclined to understand Scripture, Paul' s focus here is on receiving divine revelation. Furthermore, earlier in the chapter, Paul distinguishes between the unsaved, to whom he preached only the gospel (I Cor. 2:1,2) and the saved, to whom he preached the Mystery (vss. 6,7). Therefore, we can conclude that God has drawn a distinction between the gospel, which has the power to "jump-start" the lost (after all, the gospel IS "the power of God UNTO SALVATION," Rom. 1:16), and the further revelation of Scripture which must be understood with spiritual discernment. Listen to the majestic words of I Corinthians 1:21, "For after that in the wisdom of God the world by wisdom knew not God, it pleased God by the foolishness of preaching to save them that believe." Notice that it does NOT say, "to save those whom He chose," but rather, "to save them that BELIEVE."

A fourth passage which is often used to "prove" that an unsaved man cannot believe is Ephesians 2:1, "And you hath He quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins." The Calvinist would argue that when it says we were dead, we, therefore, could not believe. Can a dead man believe? No, of course not, right? Again, let us look at the context. Notice that the text says we were dead "in trespasses and sins." Yet look at what these "dead" people are doing in verse two, "wherein in time past ye walked" (do dead men walk?). You see, Paul's whole point here is that death, spiritually speaking, does not mean brain dead. Obviously, it does not mean physical death. Spiritual death is "separation from God." One can be spiritually dead but still have a mind to which God can minister. One can be spiritually dead and be walking around according to the course of the world and the prince of the power of the air, and so forth. We must remember that even though spiritual death means separation from God, God has done something to bridge this separation. We would agree with the Calvinist that if God had not done something to bridge this separation, man could not believe. But praise God, He has done something to bridge this gap. This is why He gave the gospel!

What conclusions can we draw from all of this? First of all, we can agree that man is utterly lost in sin. Furthermore, it means he is entirely unable to save himself. Man cannot pick himself up by his own bootstraps. This writer, as a small child on the farm, once stepped into a bushel basket and picked up on the handles. The thought of "just sort of floating around" seemed like a good idea. The only problem was, it did not work! Man cannot save himself. The Calvinist will tell you that if you even allow that man has the ability to believe, he is contributing to his own salvation. But this is faulty thinking. Let us illustrate:

If you were a million dollars in debt and a millionaire offered to pay all your bills, only on the condition that you believe he was able to do it, would your saying, "Yes, I believe it!" mean you got yourself out of debt? Of course not! And likewise, just believing that Christ provided for our salvation at Calvary does not mean that we aided in our salvation. God did it all! He provided it 100%. We did not lift a finger. You either believe it or you do not. Incidently, unsaved people believe things all the time. They believe a chair will hold them when they sit in it, or else they would

refuse to do so. The problem with the lost is not that they are unable to "believe." The problem is that they do not believe the gospel!

In summary, man is utterly lost in sin and unable to save himself. But God has intervened to the point where man is responsible to believe and in the end, man is held responsible for his unbelief.

Chapter Two:

UNCONDITIONAL ELECTION

Now, let us go on to Unconditional Election, the second point in the T.U.L.I.P. acronym. Again, we will give the traditional Calvinist position. Jerome Zanchius wrote that election is, "that eternal, sovereign, unconditional, particular and immutable act of God where he selected some from among all mankind and of every nation under Heaven to be redeemed and everlastingly saved by Christ."[6] The idea that God "selected some" for salvation also suggests that the rest are unable to be saved, at best, or actually chosen to be lost, at worst. This is known as the doctrine of dual election. Again, in all fairness, some Calvinists do not teach dual election, they only teach that God elected some to be saved. Yet Calvin himself wrote, "Many indeed, as if they wished to avert odium from God, admit election in such a way as to deny that any one is reprobated. But this is puerile and absurd, because election itself could not exist without being opposed to reprobation... Whom God passes by, He reprobates, and from no other cause than His determination to exclude them from the inheritance which He predestines for His children."[7]

What Scriptures would the Calvinist use to prove such a doctrine? Perhaps more than any other, Calvinists rely on Romans 9:11-13 to show that some are chosen to be saved, and others to be lost: "For the children being not yet born, neither having done any good or evil, that the purpose of God according to election might stand, not of works, but of Him that calleth. It was said unto her, the elder shall serve the younger. As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated." Because Romans chapter 9 is central to the Calvinist debate, all of chapter 9 of this book is devoted to it. With regard to these three verses, let us point out some important facts.

The Scripture to which Paul is referring in Romans 9:11,12 is Genesis 25:23. Here we find the account of Rebekah who is the mother of Esau and Jacob, "And the Lord said unto her, two nations are in thy womb, and two manner of people shall be separated from thy bowels; and the one people shall be stronger than the other people; and the elder shall serve the younger." Now, how do we know that Paul is not talking about Jacob and Esau individually? Because when we go back to the passage he is quoting from, it very clearly shows that the issue in Romans 9:11 is

[6] Zanchius, Op. cit. p. 39.
[7] Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion,* Ill, ch. XXIII. Sec. 1.

not the individuals, the issue is nations. God told Rebekah that there were two "nations" in her womb. The issue here is not which child was chosen to be saved, but rather, which "nation" descending from these two children would be God's chosen nation. Obviously, it was Jacob's "nation," Israel, which became the chosen nation, not Esau's "nation," Edom.

Furthermore, the verse goes on to say that "the elder shall serve the younger." We also know Paul is not referring to the individuals involved here by going back in history and studying the lives of Esau and Jacob. Did Esau ever serve Jacob, personally? No! But the descendants of Esau DID serve the descendants of Jacob. In I Chronicles 18:13 we read, "And he put garrisons in Edom; and all the Edomites became David's servants." This is Paul's whole point in Romans chapter nine. When he quotes Genesis, saying that "the elder shall serve the younger," he is talking about these nations. When he says that the purpose of God according to election might stand, it is not the election of individual people for salvation; rather, it is God's election or choice of which nation God would use to bring blessing to the earth. Theologians sometimes refer to this as "corporate election."

But what about Romans 9:13? "As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated." Again, the Calvinist would say that God loved Jacob before he was even born and He hated Esau before he was born. They will connect that statement back with what he says in verse 11, "For the children being not yet born." But, if you find where this quote comes from in Malachi chapter 1, you will see that this statement actually took place long after Jacob and Esau had died. What it is showing is how God viewed those nations which came from these two men, and God's conclusion after watching these two nations throughout the centuries. God's conclusion is: Jacob have I loved and Esau have I hated. It has nothing to do with how He felt about these two individual men; it has to do with how He viewed these two nations after hundreds of years of their existence.

Another passage that is sometimes used to teach that God picks some people to be saved and the rest are out in the cold is Ephesians 1:4. We have sometimes heard this verse misquoted like this: "According as He hath chosen us before the foundation of the world." But in fact, the verse reads, "According as He hath chosen us in Him before the foundation of the world." Those two little words, IN HIM make all the difference in the world! How is it that we are chosen? It is "in Christ!"

You see, Paul is bringing up here the great doctrine of identification with Christ. When you are identified with Christ, you receive many benefits in your spiritual life. In fact, this is the whole point of Ephesians chapter 1. We read in verse 3, "Blessed be the God and father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ." Our blessings are "in Christ." The same principle applies, for example with our spiritual baptism: Romans 6:4, "we are buried with him." How? "By baptism into death." How were we baptized unto death? "For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body" (I Cor. 12:13). When this takes place, we are identified with Christ and according to Romans chapter 6, His death, His burial and His resurrection are transferred to us.

Something else of Christ's which is transferred to us is His status as God's "elect." Isaiah 42:1 states, of Christ, "Behold my servant, whom I uphold; mine elect...." When we trust Christ, we are "in Him," and one of the blessings we receive by being in Him is that we are now "elect." God did not choose us in and of ourselves, we are elect "in Him." And until you are "in Him" by faith, you are not elect!

The idea of Unconditional Election of individual lost people for salvation flatly contradicts the clear Scriptural statements about the character and desire of God. 1 Timothy 2:1-3 says, "I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; For kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty. For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour." Now, why does God want us to have a peaceable and quiet life? Because we have a mission to perform for God, "who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth" (I Tim. 2:4). The word for "will" in verse 4 is the word for God's desirous will (Gk. thelei). What is God's desire? "That all men be saved and come to a knowledge of the truth." Now, can that verse be true and Unconditional Election also be true? Can you say on the one hand, God has only chosen some people to be saved, but really he wants all men to be saved? This would be a contradiction that is beyond the character of God.

Does the fact that God desires everyone to be saved mean everyone WILL be saved? No, of course not. God will not force salvation upon anyone. But the call to salvation goes out equally to all mankind without preference or condition, "for whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:13). "Whosoever" - does this sound like God is holding out an offer only to some people? Does it sound like a limited offer? "Whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved." Some would say, "Of course 'whosoever shall call,' but only the elect can call." But is that what the rest of the passage says? "Whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved. How then shall they call on Him in whom they have not believed? And how shall they believe in Him of whom they have not heard? And how shall they hear without a preacher? And how shall they preach, except they be sent?"

Do you see the progression that Paul is setting forth? He says they cannot call until they believe, and they cannot believe until they hear, and they cannot hear until a preacher is sent by God. Then in verse 17 it says, "so then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God." It all boils down to the fact that God sends His Word, and men can believe it or reject it. That is where Paul ends this whole progression. If a person is not able to believe, then God is not really being honest in holding out this promise of Scripture, "whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:13).

What conclusion must we draw? Scripture does not support the notion that some are chosen to be saved and others are chosen to be damned. God is, in fact, being completely honest in His offer of "whosoever" when He offers salvation to all mankind.

Chapter Three:

LIMITED ATONEMENT

The next point of Calvinism is - Limited Atonement. Once again we want to be fair in portraying Calvinism. Most Calvinists we have met do not believe in the doctrine of Limited Atonement (thankfully). However, many of them do. What is the doctrine of Limited Atonement? It is the teaching that Christ died only for those who would eventually be saved, but not for the rest of the people. Loraine Boettner writes, "In accordance with this obvious truth, the Scriptures teach that Christ died specifically for His people; and nowhere do they teach, either directly or by good and necessary inference, that He died for all men alike."[8] Several passages are given in support of this statement - John 10:11, "I am the good shepherd: the good shepherd giveth His life for the sheep." And Acts 20:28, "Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over the which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers, to feed the church of God, which He hath purchased with His own blood."

With regard to these passages, we ask: "Do these verses prove that Christ died only for 'the elect'?" No. Do they teach that He DID die for believers? Of course they do! He DID die for believers. He did die for the church. Of course He died for His sheep, His people, and His elect. But it does not say in those verses that He did NOT die for everyone else. In fact, the clear testimony of Scripture is that Christ DID die for everyone else. Consider Romans 5:6-8, "For when we were yet without strength, in due time Christ died for the ungodly. For scarcely for a righteous man will one die: yet peradventure for a good man some would even dare to die. But God commendeth His love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us." Also, II Peter 2:1-3 states, “But there were false prophets also among the people, even as there shall be false teachers among you, who privily shall bring in damnable heresies, even denying the Lord that bought them and bring upon themselves swift destruction. Ant many shall follow their pernicious ways; by reason of whom the way of truth shall be evil spoken of. And through covetousness shall they with feigned words make merchandise of you: whose judgment now of a long time lingereth not, and their damnation slumbereth not." These are unbelievers, they are lost. And yet, it says, they deny the Lord THAT BOUGHT THEM. 1 John 2:1,2: "My little children, these things I write unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous: And He is the propitiation for our sins; and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world." It is beyond our imagination how anyone could teach Limited Atonement. The Scripture is absolutely clear. Christ bought them, He is the propitiation, not only for our sins, but for the sins of the whole world. The Scripture is crystal clear on this point.

Our conclusion then is that Christ's death was suffered for everyone, but only those who believe enjoy the benefits of His suffering and death. The Apostle Paul states this just as clearly in I Timothy 4:10, where we see the distinction brought out how

[8] Boettner, *Studies in Theology,* p. 317.

that Christ could die for everyone but in a unique way for believers. "For therefore we both labour and suffer reproach, because we trust in the living God, who is the Savior of all men, specially of those that believe." Now, in what sense is God the Savior of all men? Christ died for the sins of everyone. He is the Savior whether they trust in Him or not. But there is a special relationship between those who believe and their God. Those who believe are the ones who receive the benefits of Christ's death.

Another way to illustrate the distinction which Paul draws between Christ as the Savior of "all men" but "especially of those who believe," is the use of different prepositions when referring to Christ's "ransom." In Matthew 20:28 and Mark 10:45, Christ states that He would "give His life a ransom for many." The Calvinist would point out that it only says "many," not "all." Yet Paul writes in I Timothy 2:6 that Christ "gave Himself a ransom for all." We might first point out that under the prophetic program for Israel, the chosen nation was primarily in view as recipients of Christ's sacrifice, hence, Christ's use of the word "many." But with the revelation of the Mystery to Paul, the further truth of Christ's death for Gentiles is also in view, hence, the word, "all."

Yet, as stated above, the prepositions used in each text give further insight into these two statements. When Christ spoke of being a "ransom for many," the preposition translated "for" is the Greek "anti." This word means either "against" or "instead of." It is obvious that Christ was not given as a ransom "against" anyone, therefore, He meant that He would be a ransom "instead of" many. In other words, He would take their place in bearing the penalty of sin. Paul, on the other hand, states that Christ was a ransom "for" (Gk. "huper") all. This word has a broader range of meaning than "anti." In II Corinthians 1:11; 5:12; 8:24 it is translated "on our behalf" or "on your behalf." This is the sense in which Paul uses it in I Timothy 2:6. Christ gave Himself a ransom "on the behalf of" ALL. It is certainly true that Christ did not die "instead of,' the lost, for they will still bear the pain of eternal suffering, known as the "second death" (Rev. 20:14). But it remains true that Christ died "on their behalf." And the only thing preventing their enjoyment of the blessings of the gospel is their unbelief. The fact is, they COULD be saved by trusting Christ, for His death was suffered for them, too. When the sinner trusts Christ, His death "on their behalf" becomes His death "in their place."

Chapter Four:

IRRESISTIBLE GRACE

Let us now consider "Irresistible Grace." Augustine, who was born in the fourth century, actually sowed some of the seeds of what we now call "Calvinism." Interestingly, many of these doctrines were not held before the fourth century after Christ. It was through Augustine's influence these doctrines began to be taught. It has been said that Calvin quoted Augustine more than he quoted the Scriptures! Augustine wrote, "Faith then, as well in its beginning as in its completion, is God's gift; and let no one have any doubt whatever...that this gift is given to some, while

to some it is not given."[9] Furthermore, Augustine wrote, "No free will of the creature can resist the will of God, for man cannot so will or nill as to obstruct the Divine determination or overcome the Divine power."[10] This is essentially the Calvinist position on Irresistible Grace. A passage that is sometimes used to try to prove this is Romans 9:18-19. "Therefore hath He mercy on whom He will have mercy, and whom He will He hardeneth. Thou wilt say then unto me, Why doth He yet find fault? For who hath resisted His will?" The Calvinist takes the last two sentences of verse 19 as Bible doctrine being taught by Paul. But the fact is, Paul is actually quoting the imaginary antagonist which he often uses to show his point. Notice the first part of the statement in verse 19, "Thou wilt say then unto me." Paul is anticipating the response he might get from some people. The Calvinist quotes, "For who hath resisted his will?" as proof that no one can resist God's will. But in fact, Paul corrects this misconception in verse 20, "Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God?" In other words, "Who has resisted his will?" Those who reply against God have indeed resisted His will! Far from teaching that man cannot resist God's will, Paul is actually showing how man does so every time he replies against God.

Many Bible passages clearly teach that man can and does resist God's grace. We will offer a few examples. The first, Matthew 23:37, demonstrates the great anguish Christ felt because of the rejection of His own people against Himself: "O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, thou that killest the prophets, and stonest them which are sent unto thee, how often would I have gathered thy children together, even as a hen gathereth her chickens under her wings, and ye would not." Notice carefully, that Christ did not say "ye COULD not," He said, "ye WOULD not!" They obviously could and did resist God's gracious attempts to gather and protect them.

The next passage is found in the context of John's baptism. John preached "the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins" (Luke 3:3), "But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the counsel of God against themselves, being not baptized of him" (Luke 7:30). Did the Pharisees and the lawyers reject the will of God? Absolutely! God's counsel (literally, God's "will") for them was that they be baptized and they rejected it.

In Acts 7:51 Stephen indicts Israel, "Ye stiffnecked and uncircumcised in heart and ears, ye do always resist the Holy Ghost: as your fathers did, so do ye." Does this sound like the doctrine of "irresistible grace?" No! It is just the opposite! "Ye do always resist the Holy Ghost." Can man resist God? Yes he can, according to Acts 7:51. Does man resist God? Yes, unfortunately, it appears that he does this most of the time.

Let us draw a conclusion concerning the doctrine of irresistible grace. Titus 2:11 says, "For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men." Now if God's grace were irresistible, then how many men would be saved? All of them! Are all men saved? No, yet God's grace has appeared to all men. Therefore, God's grace, though wonderful, is sometimes - yes, often times - resisted by mankind.

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[9] Augustine, *The Predestination of the Saints,* cited by Forster and Marston.
[10] Augustine, *De Corr. and Grat. 14,* cited by Zanchius.

Chapter Five:

PERSEVERANCE OF THE SAINTS

Now, let us go on to the fifth point of Calvinism. "P" in the T.U.L.I.P. acronym, stands for "Perseverance of the Saints." This is the one point of Calvinism with which, at face value, many have no problem. Many Christians hear the phrase, "Perseverance of the Saints" and they automatically think "eternal security," or "once saved, always saved." But this is not what is really meant by the Calvinist's use of the words, "Perseverance of the Saints."

The Westminster confession says, "True believers, by reason of the unchangeable love of God and His decree and covenant to give them perseverance, cannot fall away."[11] Now, let us think about this. Is this the Pauline doctrine of eternal security? "True believers, by reason of the unchangeable love of God and His decree and covenant to give them perseverance, cannot fall away." The doctrine of perseverance of the saints teaches that the reason a person does not lose his salvation is because, according to Calvinistic doctrine, God continues to give faith to the "elect," and therefore they remain saved. It may seem a bit ironic, but Calvinistic doctrine actually teaches that if a person did stop believing, he would be lost. Of course, they go on to say that a true believer will not stop believing because God keeps giving him faith.

Is this eternal security as we find it in the Pauline epistles? We submit that it is not. Where, then, do they get this kind of teaching? One passage in particular is Luke 22:32. The key here is to remember that Luke, being a part of the four gospel records concerning the earthly life of Christ, has to do with kingdom doctrine, not doctrine relating to the Dispensation of Grace. Luke 22:31 begins, "And the Lord said, Simon, Simon, behold Satan hath desired to have you (plural, the '12'), that he may sift you as wheat: But I have prayed for thee (singular, Peter), that thy faith fail not: and when thou art converted, strengthen thy brethren." Here, the reason Peter's faith does not fail is because Christ prays for it to continue. This is the closest thing in Scripture to the Calvinistic doctrine of perseverance of the saints. Why did Peter persevere? Because Christ prayed for him and his faith, that his faith would not fail. But even here, the "faith" likely refers to Peter's faithfulness to stand strong for the Lord.

But, what is eternal security according to the Apostle Paul? This is a stumbling block, frankly, for many people. Eternal security in this dispensation is not dependent on our continuing in faith. Rather, it is based on the sealing ministry of the Holy Spirit. Now, does the sealing of the Holy Spirit have anything to do with faith? Of course it does. We must believe the gospel at some point in order to be saved. Furthermore, it is the norm for a believer to continue believing for the rest of his life. But according to Paul, it is the Holy Spirit who seals our salvation, not our continued belief. Ephesians 1:13, "In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye

[11] *Westminster Confession*

were sealed with that Holy Spirit of promise, Which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, unto the praise of His glory." This is the Pauline doctrine of eternal security. The words, "after that ye believed" are actually in the "aorist" tense, which is the tense of "point action." This simply means we are sealed by the Holy Spirit at the moment we believe the gospel. It is not "if you continue" believing, it is "when" you believed that you were sealed. Now, does God desire that we keep believing? Of course He does! Continuing in faith will bring growth in our spiritual life! But our salvation is secure at the very moment we trust Christ for our salvation! Paul affirms this once more in Ephesians 4:30, "And grieve not the Holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption."

What would happen if we were unfaithful after being saved? Paul deals with this in II Timothy 2:13, "If we believe not (are not faithful), yet He abideth faithful: He cannot deny Himself." What does Paul mean by this? Well, you see, permeating Paul's epistles is the doctrine of the body of Christ. When you become a believer, you become a member of the body of Christ. This means that now you belong to him, and you are an integral part of him. Therefore, to deny you entrance into Heaven would be to deny Himself, and as Paul so clearly states, "He cannot deny Himself."

In conclusion, the Calvinistic doctrine of perseverance of the saints, is not the same as the sealing ministry of the Holy Spirit. We believe we cannot lose salvation, but for a different reason than Calvinism teaches.

PART TWO:
KEY WORDS RELATING TO CALVINISM

Chapter Six:

ELECTION

In the study of Scripture, you will find that the misunderstanding of just one or two words can often lead to disastrous results. It certainly can lead to great misunderstanding of what God is really trying to tell us. Such is the case with the words "election" and "predestination."

In this chapter, we want to answer the question, "What does election actually mean in the Scriptures?" What we will find is that it does not mean what either Calvinism or Arminianism teach. Both of these theologies will tell us that election means "chosen to be saved." This is taken for granted and becomes the major premise from which we are supposed to work. But as you know, if you know anything about logic, if the major premise is wrong then the rest of the equation is going to be wrong as well.

We will see in this chapter that election in Scripture does not mean, "chosen to be saved" at all. Actually, it primarily means to be "chosen to a position of service." We will do two things by way of introduction. We are going to look at the literal meaning of election and then we are going to summarize the meaning of election as used in Scripture.

The word "election" comes from the Greek word "eklectos." In our modern vocabulary, the word "eclectic" is a direct transliteration of this word from the Greek. What does eclectic mean? It has to do with being very selective about certain things. Where does this word originate? The prefix "ek" simply means "out of" and the word "lego" (which is actually the root word) means "to call" or "to speak." So, "eklectos" means to call out, to speak for, and call someone out unto yourself for a purpose. The word that is translated "election" is also translated "chosen," therefore, these two words can be used interchangeably. In the course of this study, we will be giving many examples of how the word is used in Scripture.

The big question then is, "to what are we chosen?" We will answer this by looking at five Biblical elections. We will show that in each case there is a special purpose for the election, and give several Scriptures for each. We will begin with the most important election of all: the "election of Christ."

THE ELECTION OF CHRIST

In Isaiah 42:1 we read, "Behold my servant, whom I uphold; mine elect, in whom my soul delighteth; I have put my spirit upon Him: he shall bring forth judgment to the Gentiles." How do we know this is referring to Christ? The text goes on to say, "He shall not cry, nor lift up, nor cause His voice to be heard in the street. A bruised reed shall He not break, and the smoking flax shall He not quench: He shall bring forth judgment unto troth" (Isa. 42:2,3). This passage is quoted in Matthew 12:18-21, clearly identifying this "elect" person as the Lord Jesus Christ.

If Isaiah 42:1 teaches us anything, it shows that "election" does not necessarily mean "chosen to be saved." It certainly does not mean this in this context, for Christ was never lost! We will see time and time again that this is not the intent of the word "election" in Scripture. Now, let us continue in this passage and see what is the purpose of Christ's election. Isaiah 42:4 says, "He shall not fail nor be discouraged, till He have set judgment in the earth: and the isles shall wait for His law." Is not this a fantastic statement? "He shall not fail nor be discouraged." How often we get discouraged when things do not seem to be going right in the earth. But it says here, Christ will not be discouraged.

Verse 5 continues, "Thus saith God the Lord, He that created the heavens, and stretched them out; He that spread forth the earth, and that which cometh out of it; He that giveth breath unto the people upon it, and spirit to Him that walk therein: I the Lord have called thee in righteousness, and will hold thine hand, and will keep thee, and give thee for a covenant of the people, for a light of the Gentiles; To open the blind eyes, to bring out the prisoners from the prison, and them that sit in

darkness out of the prison house." For what was Christ chosen? Obviously, for a very important position and a very important job: that He might bring judgment in the earth and that He would be a covenant for the people. What people does He have in mind? The people of Israel. And as He was received by the covenant people of Israel, then He could also be a light unto the Gentiles under the kingdom program. The Israelites then were to reach out with the message of Christ according to prophecy and be a light unto the Gentiles. Here in Isaiah, the Lord Jesus Christ is not elected to salvation, but to be a channel of blessing to the people of the earth. A second Scripture we want to look at is in Luke chapter 23. Here we find a little different slant to the use of the word "elect," because it is actually used here by those who were opposed to the Lord Jesus Christ. Luke 23:35 says, "And the people stood beholding. And the rulers also with them derided Him, saying, He saved others; let Him save himself, if He be Christ, the chosen of God." Here, the word translated "chosen" is the same as the word "elect." As Christ was hanging on the cross, these unbelievers were questioning the fact that He is the elect of God. They were asking, in effect, "If He is the elect, why does He not do something about this? Why does He not show Himself to be the elect, the chosen one?"

Was He really the elect? Yes, and later on Peter does refer to Christ as the elect in I Peter 2:4,6, "To whom coming, as unto a living stone, disallowed indeed of men, but chosen of God, and precious." And to what was He chosen? Verse 6 tells us, "Wherefore also it is contained in the Scripture, Behold, I lay in Sion a chief comer stone, elect, precious: and he that believeth on him shall not be confounded." Here, the Lord Jesus Christ is elect to be the chief cornerstone, which, of course, meant to be in a position of privilege and honor. The chief cornerstone is the most important stone of the building. It sets the direction of the entire building and establishes its purpose. But again, it is clear that Peter does NOT mean that Christ was chosen to be saved.

Let us summarize the purpose of Christ's election. Christ was chosen by the Father to occupy the office of Savior. As such He is the one chosen to bring blessing to mankind. It has nothing to do with Him being saved, for He was never lost. It has everything to do with His position and His calling in God's plan.

THE ELECTION OF ISRAEL

A second election that we find in Scripture is the election of the nation of Israel. Once again, let us go back to the Old Testament to establish a foundation for this election. In Isaiah 45:4 we find another election, "For Jacob my servant's sake, and Israel mine elect, I have even called thee by thy name: I have surnamed thee, though thou hast not known me." Here, Jacob, or Israel is called the elect of God. Again this brings up a question. Does this mean that all who are Israelites are automatically saved? Absolutely not! Israel was made a covenant nation before God. She was chosen in that respect, yet individuals within the nation still were responsible to exercise faith. Of course, under that program one had to demonstrate appropriate works in order to be counted as a part of Israel. Israel as a nation was considered elect. And yet to be a part of that nation, one had to be

identified with that nation. How was one identified with that nation? Circumcision provided the means for identification (Gen. 17:9-14). Gentiles could also become part of the elect nation through circumcision (Gen. 17:12), and later, by taking hold of the covenant that was given to Israel (Isa. 56:6). These things identified a person with Israel and with the Lord. If one identified with Israel under that dispensation, he too was elect.

We might ask, "Why is Israel elect?" The answer, ultimately, is because Israel was identified with Christ through the covenant, and Christ is elect. We will see that all of the elections that follow have to do with the Lord Jesus Christ Himself. He is ultimately the elect of God. If you want to be elect, you must be identified with Him.

Another key Scripture to compare with Isaiah is found in Deuteronomy, where we find an interesting statement dealing with the question of why God chose or elected Israel. Here Jehovah puts it in the negative. Deuteronomy 7:7, "The Lord did not set His love upon you, nor choose you, because ye were more in number than any people; for ye were the fewest of all people: But because the Lord loved you, and because He would keep the oath which He had sworn unto your fathers, hath the Lord brought you out with a mighty hand, and redeemed you out of the house of bondmen, from the hand of Pharaoh king of Egypt." Here again we see this principle of identification. Why did the Lord choose Israel according to this text? Israel was chosen because of the fathers. Who did we learn was already the elect from Isaiah 45:4? Jacob, or Israel was elect. Therefore, because of the fathers, and the covenant God made with the fathers, Israel as a nation was also considered elect.

Now let us go to several New Testament passages which give further insight into the election of the nation of Israel. One of the key passages is Acts 13:17, where we read, "The God of this people of Israel chose our fathers, and exalted the people when they dwelt as strangers in the land of Egypt, and with an high arm brought He them out of it." Why did God choose (or, "elect") Israel according to this passage? Israel was chosen to be exalted, and it is based on their identification with the fathers.

A second passage very crucial to this study is Romans 9:11, "For the children being not yet born, neither having done any good or evil, that the purpose of God according to election might stand, not of works, but of Him that calleth. It was said unto her, The elder shall serve the younger. As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated." As we pointed out before, Jacob and Esau represent two nations according to Genesis 25:23, "And the Lord said unto her, Two nations are in thy womb...." The issue here is not which man was chosen to be saved, but rather, which nation would be chosen to serve God.

A third passage echoes this theme of God's choice of Israel as a nation. Romans 11:28, "As concerning the gospel, they are enemies for your sakes: but as touching the election, they are beloved for the fathers' sakes." Once again we see that identification with the fathers is the basis for Israel's national election. Because of

the fathers (Abraham, Isaac, Jacob), the Israelites held a special position of blessing.

A fourth passage dealing with Israel's election is I Peter 1:2, "Elect according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, through sanctification of the Spirit, unto obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ." Once again we find an election. Many (perhaps most) Bible teachers take this particular verse to mean election of the individual to salvation. But this is not Peter's intent at all. First of all, he is addressing the Jews. In verse 1, he calls them the "strangers scattered abroad." These words come from one Greek word, "diaspora," or literally, the dispersion. This refers to the Jews (and proselytes) who had gathered in Jerusalem for Pentecost, but were subsequently scattered. James refers to them as the twelve tribes which are "scattered abroad" (again, "diaspora"). In chapter 2:9, Peter clearly identifies this election as national, "But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation..." (I Pet. 2:9).

Peter is consistently using the word "election" in the same way that it was used of Israel in the Old Testament: that they were a covenant people, elect according to the foreknowledge of God. The thought here is not that God picked out certain individuals to be saved, but rather, God chose a certain nation through which blessing would come to the world. To become elect, one had to identify with the nation of Israel, whether as natural Jews who believed or as Gentile proselytes who joined their faith.

Another passage which refers to Israel's election is I Peter 5:13, "the church that is at Babylon." Notice that the word "church" here is in italics and the passage literally reads, "she that is at Babylon elected together with you saluteth you." Again, in this context, Peter is writing to Jewish people, under the kingdom program and is simply informing them that those kingdom saints in Babylon were also a part of that elect nation.

In II Peter 1:10 we find a reference which ought to really make us stop and think. "Wherefore the rather, brethren, give diligence to make your calling and election sure: for if ye do these things, ye shall never fall." To what election is he referring? Remember what Peter has already told his readers in I Peter 2:9, "ye are... an holy nation." II Peter is written to the same group (II Pet. 3:1). It is the election as a nation which Peter has in mind and is saying to these people, give diligence to make your calling and election sure. In other words, make sure of your identification with the nation Israel through doing the things listed in II Peter 1:5-7, "And beside this, giving all diligence, add to your faith virtue; and to virtue knowledge; and to knowledge temperance; and to temperance patience; and to patience godliness; and to godliness brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness charity."

Peter is literally telling these Jews of the kingdom program that the way to make their election sure is to do these things along with their faith. If they obeyed this, Peter tells them, "ye shall never fall: for so an entrance shall be ministered unto you abundantly into the everlasting kingdom of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ."

Revelation 17:14 says, "These shall make war with the Lamb, and the Lamb shall overcome them: for He is Lord of lords and King of kings: and they that are with Him are called, and chosen, (elect) and faithful." Who are the "elect" in this passage? Again, it is Israel who is in view in the Book of Revelation: "And hast made us unto our God kings and priests: and we shall reign on the earth" (Rev.5:10). Who is identified in Scripture as a "kingdom of priests"? It is the nation Israel: "And ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation. These are the words which thou shalt speak unto the children of Israel" (Exod. 19:6). It will be this elect nation who will be with Christ when He overcomes the ten kings who are empowered by the beast (Rev. 17:12-14).

Two more passages in the gospels need to be mentioned in this regard. Matthew 24:22 and Mark 13:20-27 are parallel passages. Matthew 24:22 says, "And except those days should be shortened, there shall no flesh be saved: but for the elect's sake those days shall be shortened." The context here is the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21), "for then shall be great tribulation." Who bears the brunt of the great tribulation? The nation Israel. These are the elect that Christ is referring to and it is because of the elect that the days will be shortened.

In Luke 18:7 the word "elect" is used in the context of a parable, "Shall not God avenge His own elect, which cry day and night unto Him, though he bear long with them." Again, the teaching here has to do with the tribulation period and how God will avenge His elect, his nation Israel, very speedily.

Let us summarize the election of the nation Israel. Israel was elected by God for this purpose: she was to hold a privileged position as a vessel through which God could bless all people. This purpose goes all the way back to God's call of Abraham, "And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great; and thou shalt be a blessing: And I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed" (Gen. 12:2,3). And God chose the people of Israel to be the channel of salvation to the earth. In John 4:22, the Lord Jesus Christ, speaking to the woman at the well said, "salvation is of the Jews." They were that chosen channel of salvation through which all the people of the earth could come to God. Unfortunately, there were times when they were such a poor testimony that they could not be used of God even though they were chosen to be that vessel.

Once again, we see the purpose of election here is not picking certain ones to be saved, but rather, it has to do with putting them in a privileged position, where they can then minister unto others.

THE ELECTION OF THE TWELVE APOSTLES

Now, let us move on to the election of the twelve apostles. The first passage we will consider is Luke 6:13. Here is another passage which reemphasizes our point that election is not God's choice to save someone. Our verse states, "And when it was day, He called unto Him His disciples: and of them He chose twelve, whom

also He named apostles." Does their election here mean that they were automatically saved? Notice the list of names found in verse 14, "Simon, (whom He also named Peter) and Andrew his brother, James and John, Philip and Bartholomew, Matthew and Thomas, James the son of Alphaeus, and Simon called Zelotes, and Judas the brother of James, and Judas Iscariot, which also was the traitor." We remind the reader that back in verse 13, it does not say "He chose eleven, whom He named apostles," it says He chose "twelve," and one of those twelve was Judas. Now, Judas, obviously, was an unbeliever because we read later that he fell from his office and is referred to as "the son of perdition." Judas was obviously not elected to salvation, yet the Scripture says he was chosen right along with the other apostles.

Our next passage further explains the position to which Judas was chosen. Was Judas a real apostle? Let us see what the Scripture says. Acts 1:15 says, "In those days Peter stood up in the midst of the disciples, and said (the number of names together were about an hundred and twenty), Men and brethren, this Scripture must needs have been fulfilled, which the Holy Ghost by the mouth of David spake before concerning Judas, which was guide to them that took Jesus. For he was numbered with us, and had obtained part of this ministry." Verse 18 continues, "Now this man purchased a field with the reward of iniquity; and falling headlong, he burst asunder in the midst, and all his bowels gushed out. And it was known unto all the dwellers at Jerusalem; insomuch as that field is called in their proper tongue, Aceldama, that is to say, The field of blood. For it is written in the Book of Psalms, let his habitation be desolate, and let no man dwell therein: and his bishopric let another take." Judas was "numbered with" the apostles, he "obtained a part of this ministry," he was referred to as an "apostle" when the Lord chose him, and he did hold a "bishopric." He definitely was an apostle. But he definitely was lost. Once more, it is clear that election does not mean "called to salvation," but rather, it is being "called to a position of service."

Several other Scriptures illustrate the same thing: John 6:70, "Jesus answered them, Have not I chosen you twelve, and one of you is a devil?" John 13:17-18, "If ye know these things, happy are ye if ye do them. I speak not of you all: I know whom I have chosen: but that the Scripture may be fulfilled, He that eateth bread with me hath lifted up his heel against me." Some might interpret the words, "I know whom I have chosen," to mean that Christ really only chose eleven of these and the one who would lift up his heel was not actually chosen. But this is not what He means at all. Christ is literally saying, "I know whom I have chosen," that is, "I know thoroughly the thoughts and the intent and the innermost of ideas of those whom I have chosen." He is not at all saying that Judas was not chosen. Rather, Christ is affirming that He knows the intentions of each one that He chose, including Judas. Because of this, Christ could predict Judas' actions.

Actually, it was crucial for Christ to predict Judas' actions, if for no other reason, so that the other eleven apostles would not question His authenticity after Judas' betrayal. After all, they might have thought, "If Christ could not even recognize Judas as a betrayer, how do we know He was the genuine Messiah?" Therefore, Christ told them, "Now I tell you before it come, that when it is come to pass, ye

may believe that I am He" (John 13:19). Then, still in the context of Judas' betrayal, Christ states, "Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that receiveth whomsoever I send receiveth me; and he that receiveth me receiveth Him that sent me" (John 13:20). This verse illustrates how Judas could be chosen as an apostle and even bear fruit, all the while he himself was an unbeliever. Inevitably, as the apostles, including Judas, went preaching, people believed on Christ and, therefore, on the Father as well. In verse 20, Christ is simply confirming to the eleven apostles that even though Judas would betray him, those who came to faith under his preaching had genuinely received Christ and the Father. This once more reaffirms the fact that election is not God's choice of whom He will save, but rather it is His choice of those who will serve.

John 15:16 states, "ye have not chosen me, but I have chosen you, and ordained you." It is essential to remember that the context here is with regard to the twelve apostles. "I have chosen you, and ordained you, that ye should go and bring forth fruit, and that your fruit should remain: that whatsoever ye shall ask of the Father in my name, He may give it you." This is spoken in particular to the twelve apostles as those who will have great authority in the kingdom. Verse 19 continues, "If ye were of the world, the world would love his own: but because ye are not of the world, but I have chosen you out of the world, therefore the world hateth you." The choice God is making here relates not to salvation, but rather to God's desire that the apostles bear fruit, and that whatever they ask will be given to them of the Father. This last statement definitely pertains to the apostles under the kingdom program, and is not a "blank check" promise for all believers today. But again, the election taking place is not to salvation, but rather to a privileged position of service.

Finally, Acts chapter 1 again uses the word for "elect" in the context of the apostles. Acts 1:2, "Until the day in which He was taken up, after that He through the Holy Ghost had given commandments unto the apostles whom He had chosen." Acts 1:24, "And they prayed, and said, Thou, Lord, which knowest ate hearts of all men, shew whether of these two thou hast chosen." This, of course, refers to God's choice of Matthias, "that he may take part of this ministry and apostleship, from which Judas by transgression fell" (Acts 1:25).

What was God's purpose in choosing the twelve apostles? The apostles were elected to a special position so that they could bear fruit and minister to others. A major aspect of this ministry was to be a channel of blessing, and salvation to the world.

THE ELECTION OF THE BODY OF CHRIST

The next category of election which is found in Scripture, is the election of the Body of Christ. At this point we must emphasize that the doctrine of "identification" is the key to understanding election, particularly, the election of the Body of Christ. Ephesians 1:3,4 says, "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ: According as He hath chosen us in Him before the foundation of the world, that we

should be holy and without blame before Him in love." The two little words "in Him" hold the key to understanding election. Some teach and even misquote this verse by saying, "According as He hath chosen us before the foundation of the world." This is not what the passage says. Rather, it says, "as He hath chosen us IN HIM." Our election is based on being identified with Christ.

Beginning in verse 4, Paul enumerates some of the "spiritual blessings in heavenly places" that he has just referred to in verse 3. One of the spiritual blessings which accompanies our salvation is the fact that we are elect in Christ.

In the following verses, He proceeds to list several other blessings as well. Verse 5 says, "Having predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the good pleasure of His will." Notice that he does not say that some people are predestined to be saved, but rather, those who are in Christ are predestinated unto the "adoption of sons" (the word "children" in verse 5 is actually the Greek, "huios," or "sons"). Verse 6 goes on to say, "To the praise of the glory of His grace, wherein He hath made us accepted in the beloved." Here is another of our "all spiritual blessings in heavenly places." We are made to be "accepted," But again, notice that this blessing is only "in the beloved," that is, "in Christ." You see, election to a privileged position of service is just one of many spiritual blessings which we receive when we are "in Christ." These blessings were all planned by God, "before the foundation of the world" (Eph. 1:4), to be given to anyone who would believe. They apply to the believer the moment that person trusts in Christ. "That we should be to the praise of His glory, who first trusted in Christ. In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that Holy Spirit of promise" (Eph. 1:12,13). The question is not, "am I one of the elect?" Rather, the question should be, "how can I be 'in Christ'?" And the answer given in this text is: by believing the gospel of your salvation.

Now let us consider Romans 8:33. Here we find another reference to the election of the Body of Christ. "Who shall lay anything to the charge of God's elect"? It is evident that Paul is using the word "elect" here in reference to a group, for it is in the plural. The question is, what group does he have in mind?

One elect group we have already considered is the nation which would proceed from Jacob, "For the children being not yet born, neither having done any good or evil, that the purpose of God according to election might stand, not of works, but of him that calleth; It was said unto her (Rebekah), The elder shall serve the younger" (Rom. 9:11,12). It must be remembered *that the context in which this was stated was not with* regard to Esau and Jacob individually, but rather with regard to the nations which would proceed from them, "And the Lord said unto her, Two nations are in thy womb, and two manner of people shall be separated from thy bowels; and the one people shall be stronger than the other people; and the elder shall serve the younger" (Gen. 25:23). Now, is Paul referring to THIS group of people, the nation of Israel, when he speaks of "God's elect" in Romans 8:33? Surely not, for in Romans chapter 11, Paul speaks of the "fall" and the "casting away" of Israel (Rom. 11:12,15). Then, he speaks of a new group in chapter 12, the Body of

Christ: "So we, being many, are one body in Christ, and every one members one of another" (Rom. 12:5). This Body of Christ is God's elect today.

Romans 8:28-30 is often used by some to teach that there is a certain order that has to be followed; that God picks certain people to be saved and then several other things happen afterwards. This text will be covered in chapter 7 of this book which examines the subject of predestination.

The next reference where we find election used with regard to the Body of Christ is in Colossians 3:12. Here the elect again are simply mentioned almost in passing. Paul writes, "Put on therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved, bowels of mercies, kindness, humbleness of mind, meekness, long suffering." How do we know he is referring here to the Body of Christ? Two things should be noted.

First, in the broader context of the Book of Colossians, Paul has already identified himself as a minister to Christ's body, "which is the church" (Col. 1:24). Therefore, these Colossian believers were a part of this body.

The second reason we know Paul is addressing the Body of Christ is that in the immediate context, he has just stated that as believers who are "risen with Christ" (Col. 31), we "have put on the new man" (vs. 10). What is the "new man"? Most commentators say it refers to "the new nature" of the believer. However, Paul defines the "new man" as the Body of Christ in Ephesians. Referring to Jew and Gentile, Paul writes, "For He is our peace, who hath made both one, and hath broken down the middle wall of partition between us; Having abolished in His flesh the enmity, even the law of commandments contained in ordinances; for to make IN HIMSELF of twain ONE NEW MAN, so making peace; And that He might reconcile both unto God IN ONE BODY by the cross, having slain the enmity thereby" (Eph. 2:14-16). The "new man" in Colossians 3:10 is the Body of Christ which we have "put on" by faith.

Now, why does Paul bring up the subject of the elect in this context? He is doing so to impress upon us the seriousness of our living before the Lord and before the world around us. He is trying to catch our attention so that we will stop and ask, "Why should I live a holy life? Why should I put on the 'bowels of mercies, kindness, humbleness of mind' etc."? Why should we do these things? Paul is stating a very profound thought here: he is saying that you should do this as the elect of God. We should live a holy life because we are part of the Body of Christ!

The next passage we want to consider is I Thessalonians 1:4. The context, beginning in verse 2 says, "We give thanks to God always for you all, making mention of you in our prayers; Remembering without ceasing your work of faith, and labour of love, and patience of hope in our Lord Jesus Christ in the sight of God and our Father; Knowing, brethren beloved, your election of God." Here again he associates their privileged position of being the elect of God with the practical aspect of living the Christian life. In verse 3, we have a summary of what the Christian life is all about. Remember what Paul wrote when he told the Corinthian believers about the passing away of the gifts of tongues, prophecy and knowledge

(I Cor. 13:8-10). What did he say would remain as the normal course of the Christian life? "Faith, hope, and love" (I Cor. 13:13) would remain.

When we come to I Thessalonians chapter 1, we see this same theme. Actually, this theme is developed in all of Paul's writings. Here, Paul praises them for their "work of faith, labor of love, and patience of hope" (I Thess. 1:3). The work of faith here has to do with the outworking of the faith that you have in Christ and really putting some shoe leather onto what you believe. The labor of love has to do with the labor that we expend in behalf of others. Finally, the patience of hope refers to waiting for the return of the Lord Jesus Christ, which really is the major theme in I and II Thessalonians. The point Paul is making here is that because we are the elect of God, we should exercise the three graces of "faith, hope and love." He has not addressed how we became the elect of God, but rather, how we should live as the elect of God.

Our next passage is II Timothy 2:10, "I endure all things for the elect's sakes that they may also obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus with eternal glory." This verse has often been twisted by some to teach something other than what it is really saying. For example, some would suggest that Paul is saying that he is doing something so that the elect may obtain salvation, period. The Calvinist would suggest that he means that the "elect" are out there just waiting to be saved, and Paul is suffering so he can be at the right place at the right time when they finally believe.

This is not at all what Paul is talking about! Notice that when he says, "I endure all things for the elect's sake," it is not merely that they obtain salvation. He qualifies his statement at the end of the verse by saying, "that they may obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus WITH ETERNAL GLORY" (II Tim. 2:10). The people he is referring to already have salvation, "which is in Christ Jesus." That is, the way to have salvation is to be "in Christ," and the way to be "in Christ" is to believe the "gospel of your salvation" (Eph. 1:13). And when you are "in Christ," you are now "elect" because Christ is "the elect of God" (Isa. 42:1). Here in II Timothy, the apostle is not merely talking about getting to Heaven (which we do not want to diminish), but Paul had a greater burden. He wanted people not only to get to Heaven but he wanted them to get there "WITH ETERNAL GLORY." That is, he wanted them to get there and receive rewards because when you receive rewards, you receive greater glory throughout eternity. This, in turn, glorifies God, which was Paul's greatest goal in life (as should be ours)!

The next passage is Titus 1:1, "Paul, a servant of God, and an apostle of Jesus Christ, according to the faith of God's elect, and the acknowledging of the truth which is after godliness." What "truth" is Paul referring to here? Verse 2 continues, "In hope of eternal life, which God, that cannot lie, promised before the world began; But hath in due times manifested His word through preaching, which is committed unto me according to the commandment of God our Saviour." The "truth which is after godliness" is the revelation given to the apostle Paul for the Gentiles, also known as the "Dispensation of the Grace of God" and "the Mystery" (or, "secret") hidden from past ages and generations (see Eph. 3:1-3). Paul's point

again is not to show how anyone became the "elect of God," but rather to show that those who are a part of God's elect (i.e., the body of Christ) can become godly through faith in the message which God committed to Paul.

Let us now consider a passage that is sometimes used to prove that election means "elected unto salvation." II Thessalonians 2:13 says, "But we are bound to give thanks alway to God for you, brethren beloved of the Lord, because God hath from the beginning chosen you to salvation through sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth." To properly understand this verse, two things should be noted. First, the word for "chosen" in this text is not the usual word for election. Rather, it is a word which simply means to "take unto yourself' or to "receive unto yourself." This is very important in this context.

The second thing to note is the context of II Thessalonians chapter 2. The Thessalonian believers had received a teaching that they might have missed the resurrection and that they were going to be exposed to the tribulation period. The purpose of this letter is to explain to them that that simply is not the case. In chapter 2, Paul speaks to them of the tribulation period, and "the man of sin" (verse 3), which is the Antichrist. In verse 8, he speaks of how that wicked one will be revealed, and the Spirit of the Lord will consume him with the spirit of His mouth and destroy him with the brightness of His coming. He is definitely talking about the tribulation period in this context. But then, to give a word of comfort unto the Thessalonians, Paul says in verse 13, "But we are bound to give thanks alway to God for you, brethren beloved of the Lord, because God hath from the beginning chosen you to salvation." Salvation from what? In this context, God has chosen us to be saved (or, delivered) from the tribulation period.

Of course, Paul taught this same truth in I Thessalonians 5:9 where he very clearly said, "For God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation." Again, the salvation spoken of here is from the tribulation period. II Thessalonians 2:13 is a reminder of what Paul had already taught them in his previous letter. God has chosen to deliver the Body of Christ from the tribulation period. How can an individual sinner become a part of this blessed company? The end of verse 13 tells us, "through sanctification of the Spirit and (or, 'even') belief of the truth." That is, the setting apart of the Spirit for this blessing is made effective when one believes the truth. And again, what "truth" does Paul have in mind here? He tells us in verse 14, "Whereunto He called you by our gospel." Once more, it is the gospel which is "the power of God unto salvation to everyone that believeth" (Rom. 1:16).

What is the purpose of the election of the Body of Christ? It is to serve as ambassadors of Christ and to be channels of God's blessing to mankind. Today it is not the nation Israel which is the channel of God's blessing to the earth. Instead, it is the Body of Christ. This is whom God has chosen in the Dispensation of Grace to be the channel through which the source of blessing (Christ) is proclaimed.

Perhaps II Corinthians 4:7 illustrates this best, "But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us." Is this not beautiful? "We have this treasure in earthen vessels." What is the earthen

vessel? It is we, as it were, "clay pots." The vessel is not glorious in and of itself. But what do we have in us when we trust Christ? We have the most glorious message that has ever been revealed to man, "But if our gospel be hid, it is hid to them that are lost: In whom the god of this world hath blinded the minds of them which believe not, lest the light of the glorious gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine unto them" (II Cor. 4:3,4). The glorious Gospel of Grace is a precious trust deposit which has been entrusted to us. This is the treasure in an earthen vessel that the excellency might be in God, the power might be of God, not of us. This is our calling. This is the purpose of our election: that we might be that channel of blessing today.

THE ELECTION OF THE APOSTLE PAUL

A final "election" which is found in Scripture is the election of the Apostle Paul. Paul's election differs from that of the twelve apostles in that his calling pertains to the heavenly program rather than the earthly program which was committed unto them. To the twelve apostles was committed the kingdom upon the earth. Christ clearly told Peter and the Twelve, "...ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28). But, to the Apostle Paul was given the ministry which pertains to the heavenly program, "For our conversation (citizenship) is in heaven" (Phil. 3:20).

The Book of Acts makes reference to Paul's election and its purpose: "But the Lord said unto him, Go thy way: for he is a chosen vessel (or an elect vessel) unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel" (Acts 9:15). Also in Acts 22:14, Annanias "a devout man according to the law" (verse 12) states, "The God of our fathers hath chosen thee, that thou shouldest know his will, and see that Just One, and shouldest hear the voice of His mouth." Paul's calling was clearly to be an apostle, as he himself states, "Paul, called to be an apostle of Jesus Christ through the will of God" (I Cor. 1:1) This apostleship is further defended in chapter 9, "Am I not an apostle? am I not flee? have I not seen Jesus Christ our Lord? are ye not my work in the Lord?" (I Cor. 9:1). Paul was very clearly called unto apostleship and to a position of privilege as a source of blessing to the Gentiles. This is consistent with the purpose of all of the five elections that we find in Scripture, including Christ's.

The election of Christ (Isa. 42:1) as the source of all blessing establishes the foundation on which the other four elections of Scripture rest. The rest of the elections "channel" those blessings, whether they be the earthly blessings, including the spiritual blessings that were promised to the kingdom saints, or whether they be the "spiritual blessings in heavenly places" (Eph. 1:3) to the Body of Christ. All of these are channels through various individuals. It is interesting to note the balance in these elections. Christ is ultimately "the elect of God." The nation of Israel was a chosen nation with chosen apostles to go along with that nation. This nation of twelve tribes was given twelve apostles. On the other hand, God's chosen vessel today is the Church, the Body of Christ, which is "one Body" (I Cor. 12:13; Eph. 4:4). Accordingly, this one Body was given one apostle which corresponds to that one Body.

Chapter Seven:

PREDESTINATION

Many times when an event or even a tragedy occurs, someone will say, "Well, I guess it was just meant to happen." Have you ever heard or said this? The world calls this attitude "fatalism," or in more common language, "the fickle finger of fate." Calvinistic theology calls this "predestination." Interestingly, the Islamic religion holds tenaciously to the doctrine of predestination. A familiar expression among Muslims is, "it was Allah's will." They will apply this to virtually everything that happens: good, bad, or indifferent, "It was Allah's will." Of course, our main concern should not be what the world or the theologians or the Islamic religion thinks. Our main concern is what the Bible says, and in this chapter, we are going to be see that the Bible does not say what many think it says about predestination. Many Christians have a vague notion that election and predestination mean the same thing. Usually they think it means that God picks out some people to be saved and passes others by, or even picks out some to be damned. In chapter 6, we showed from the Scriptures that election does not mean that God picks out certain ones to be saved. Perhaps the most conclusive way to show this is from Isaiah 42:1 where the Lord Jesus Christ Himself is referred to as God's "elect." It is obvious that the Lord Jesus Christ was not "elected" to be saved, for He was never lost. His election has nothing to do with being saved. Rather, His election has everything to do with being put into a position of service and being the source of all blessing.

We further showed that none of the five elections of Scripture have to do with picking out someone to be saved, but rather to God's positioning of a person or a group into a special place of service. This is true of the twelve apostles, including Judas. Judas was also called one of the elect apostles even though he fell from his position. He was put into the position of being one of the twelve apostles for a time. The nation Israel was put into a special position, therefore, they are called "elect." The Body of Christ is put in a special position, and, likewise, called "the elect." The Apostle Paul was put in a special position, elected to be the apostle of the Gentiles.

In this chapter, we are going to see that predestination refers primarily to the predetermined goal that God has for every believer. We will see from the Scriptures that predestination does not mean that God picks someone out for salvation. Predestination means that God has great plans for those who become saved. Once a person becomes saved, predestination relates to what God will do with that person now, and what He will do unto that person and for that person for eternity. This is what predestination is all about.

The ultimate goal of predestination is that the believer in Christ be conformed to the image of Christ. Predestination means that every last person who places their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ WILL BE conformed to the image of Christ. It may be sooner, or it may be later, but it will happen, for it has been predetermined by the Lord that it will be so. Of course, as they say, "the sooner, the better!"

The first thing we need to do is to understand the meaning of the word, "predestination." Then we will show where this word is found in Scripture. The word "predestination" is actually seldom found in the Bible. Many folks seem to have the notion, perhaps because of some preaching they have heard, that the Bible is just filled with predestination, here, there, and everywhere. But the fact is that this word is found only six times in the Bible. And then, it is not always translated "predestination." We will be considering every occurrence of the original word even when it is translated in different ways.

The Greek word for predestination is "proorizo." The prefix, "pro" means "before" and "horizo' means a boundary. Incidently, this is the word from which we get our English word "horizon." A horizon is an imaginary line, or boundary, between the earth and the sky. Putting the two words together, we get, "proorizo' or, "predestination," which means to establish a boundary beforehand. In other words, God has chosen to establish certain boundaries in advance. When considering this literal definition, two questions come to mind: 1) Whose boundaries are preset? 2) What are these preset boundaries?

Let us go to the Scriptures and consider the uses of predestination. In Acts 4:28 the word is used not about the predestination of a believer, but rather it is referring to the Lord Jesus Christ. Beginning in verse 27 we read, "For of a truth against thy holy child Jesus, whom thou hast anointed, both Herod, and Pontius Pilate, with the Gentiles, and the people of Israel, were gathered together, For to do whatsoever thy hand and thy counsel determined before" (Acts 4:27,28). It is important to realize that these words actually comprise a prayer, so when it says "thy hand," it is referring to God's hand. In other words, God's hand "determined before" (prooridzo) the boundaries of what would become of Christ. God predestined that the Lord Jesus Christ would be crucified. It was part of God's pre-determined plan. It was not a surprise. It was not a mistake. It certainly was a sin for those people to do it, but, nevertheless, it was part of God's plan that Christ should die. It does not refer to believers here at all in this use of predestination.

Now, let us look at the next reference in I Corinthians 2:7, "But we speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, *even* the hidden *wisdom,* which God ordained before the world unto our glory." Here, the words "ordained before" again come from "proorizo," or predestined. Paul is referring here to the Mystery which was hidden, but which God predestined before the world unto our glory. This tells us that the Mystery program, even though it was kept secret, was in the mind of God even before the world (lit. "ages") began. It was not just an afterthought used to replace Israel's program when they rejected the Messiah. Again, predestination in this passage has nothing to do with a believer being predestined to salvation. It is simply God's choice to plan and eventually reveal the Mystery through Paul, who tells us time and again that it was first revealed to him. I Corinthians 2:8 goes on to say, "Which none of the princes of this world knew: for had they known *it,* they would not have crucified the Lord of glory." Here is one of the reasons why God kept the Mystery a secret. Part of the Mystery is that the cross would provide payment for the sins of ALL mankind. God kept that secret, for if Satan had known what the cross would fully accomplish, he would not have wanted to see Christ

crucified. Therefore, God kept it a secret so that His predetermined plan of salvation would be carried out.

The next passage under our consideration is in Romans 8:29,30. The previous two passages do not refer to predestination with respect to believers. One refers to Christ and the other refers to the Mystery. But now in Romans 8:29-30, we find the word predestination twice, and it definitely refers to believers. Verse 29 begins, "For whom He did foreknow, He also did predestinate." Our immediate question is, to what did He predestinate them? To be saved? No, the verse goes on to say, *"to be* conformed to the image of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren." The predestination in verse 29 refers to the goal that God has for every believer in Jesus Christ: that they would be conformed to His image. The fact is that all Christians will one day be conformed to the image of Christ, and again we say, "the sooner the better!" As we grow in the Word of God, rightly divided, we become conformed to the image of Christ. If we refuse to grow in our faith, it will have to wait. But if one is truly saved, he will eventually be conformed to the image of Christ even though it may not happen until the judgment seat of Christ, instead of during this life. But either way, God has predestined that it will happen.

Now, let us go to the next verse, Romans 8:30, and notice another aspect of predestination, "Moreover whom He did predestinate, them He also called: and whom He called, them He also justified: and whom He justified, them He also glorified." Here we see a progression that is based on predestination. God predestined those who believe, (members of the Body of Christ), not only to be conformed to the image of Christ, but also to be glorified. Verse 30 ends, "them He also glorified." And indeed all believers will be glorified to some degree. Some will be glorified to a greater glory than others, but everyone who is "in Christ" will be glorified. This has been predetermined by God.

The next passage in which we find the word "predestinated" is Ephesians 1:5. It is interesting that, aside from the two passages in Acts 4:28 and 1 Corinthians 2:7, we find all of the passages on predestination in two chapters of the Bible, Romans chapter 8 and Ephesians chapter 1. Here is another aspect of our predestination, "Having predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to Himself, according to the good pleasure of His will" (Eph. 1:5). Part of the blessing we get when we trust Christ is that we are predestined to the position of sonship. Again, predestination does not mean that God has predetermined who He will save, rather, it refers to the things God will do for those who become saved.

The final use of the word predestination is found in Ephesians 1:11, "In whom also we have obtained an inheritance, being predestinated according to the purpose of Him who worketh all things after the counsel of His own will." To what are the saints predestinated according to this verse? They are predestinated "to obtaining an inheritance." What kind of inheritance does Paul have in mind here? We usually think of an inheritance as getting something in material terms, whether it be a house, land or money. But, here we have an inheritance that is in the spiritual realm.

In Romans, we find a passage which more fully explains what this inheritance is all about. Now, an inheritance is something you are promised in the future. What are we predestined to receive in the future? Romans 8:17 says, "And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with *Him,* that we may be also glorified together." In what way will we be joint-heirs with Christ? Paul tells us in II Timothy 2: 12, "If we suffer, we shall also reign with *Him:* if we deny *Him,* He also will deny us." The predestination which Paul speaks of has to do with an inheritance, and the inheritance in particular that Paul mentions is that when we suffer, we will reign with Christ. God has predetermined that this will be so.

So far we have looked at the six occurrences of predestination in Scripture and not one of them has anything to do with being "picked out" to be saved. One has to do with Christ being set forth as One who would die. One has to do with the Mystery being known and planned by God before the ages began. The other four have to do with the results of being a believer: glorification, adoption and inheritance.

An illustration which is helpful in understanding predestination is that of boarding an airliner. When you get on an airplane that is scheduled to fly from, say, New York to California, you are "destined" to get to California (barring a hijacking or a crash!). Predestination, as portrayed in Scripture, has nothing to do with WHO gets on the airplane. But it has everything to do with WHERE the airplane is going. When you trust Christ, you get on the Divine airliner that never crashes, is never late, and it always gets to its destination. Predestination means that once you trust Christ, you have boarded that airliner and now you are going to get to the destination. Whether or not you get on the airliner has not been predetermined, only what happens after you get on!

Chapter Eight:

FOREKNOWLEDGE

The next word in our study is "foreknowledge." The biblical words for foreknowledge and foreknow come from the Greek words "proginosko" and "prognosis." We are perhaps more familiar with the word, "prognosis," which comes right over into English out of the Greek. This is what we call a transliteration. It is a letter for letter translation of a word. What does prognosis mean? It simply means "to know before." Pro, again means "before" just as with the word for predestination. But instead of boundary being established in advance, here it is a pre-knowledge of something. Gnosis is the Greek word for knowledge. Therefore, "foreknowledge" means to know something beforehand, before it happens.

In the first chapter, we mentioned two views of foreknowledge; one says that foreknowledge is informative and the other says foreknowledge is determinative. The "informative" view states that God's foreknowledge is a matter of looking ahead to see what will happen and, therefore, knowing it because He looked ahead. The "determinative" view states that God has already determined to so

something and, therefore, He knows it will happen. Which is the correct view, according to Scripture?

Before giving an answer to this question, we will first look at each use of the word "foreknowledge" (or forms of this word) in Scripture. As with predestination, there is not an overwhelming number of occurrences of this word in the Bible. Because of this, it is possible to do a quite thorough job of determining what the Scripture teaches on this subject. We will divide our study into the areas of human foreknowledge and Divine foreknowledge.

Our first text is Acts 26:4-5. In this context, we find the Apostle Paul standing before Agrippa when he says, beginning in verse 2, "I think myself happy, king Agrippa, because I shall answer for myself this day before thee touching all the things whereof I am accused of the Jews: Especially *because I know* thee to be expert in all customs and questions which are among the Jews: wherefore I beseech thee to hear me patiently. My manner of life from my youth, which was at the first among mine own nation at Jerusalem, know all the Jews." In other words Paul is saying, "the Jews know me. They know my manner of life. They know my upbringing. They know my experience of being raised, sitting at the feet of Gamaliel." They knew many things about him. Verse 5 states, "which knew me from the beginning." The Greek text literally reads, "who foreknew me." Here, the word "foreknow" does not even mean to know something in the future. It simply means that the Jews in Jerusalem knew all about Paul previous to his conversion.

Another occurrence of "foreknowledge" which also refers to human wisdom is found in II Peter 3:17. Again, we need to see the context. In verse 15, Peter writes, "And account *that* the long suffering of our Lord *is* salvation; even as our beloved Paul also according to the wisdom given unto him hath written unto you; As also in all *his* epistles, speaking in them of these things; in which are some things hard to be understood, which they that are unlearned and unstable wrest, (or twist) as *they do* also the other Scriptures, unto their own destruction." Now, what Peter has said here is there are people who will take Paul's Epistles and twist them. Perhaps they will twist them to try to make them say what they want them to say or twist them to make them say something they really do not mean. Peter continues in verse 17, "Ye therefore, beloved, seeing ye know *these things* before, beware lest ye also, being led away with the error of the wicked, fall from your own steadfastness." Again we find the word "foreknowledge," only it is translated "know before." Why were they able to know these things in advance? The answer is because Peter has already told them.

Now, let us move on to Divine foreknowledge. Here we will find some insight into what God's foreknowledge is all about. Remember our question: is God's foreknowledge based on looking into the future or is God's foreknowledge based on His own predetermined plan?

The first category is foreknowledge of Christ's death. In Acts 2:22-23 we read, "Ye men of Israel, hear these words; Jesus of Nazareth, a man approved of God among you by miracles and wonders and signs, which God did by Him in the midst

of you, as ye yourselves also know: Him, being delivered by the determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God, ye have taken and by wicked hands have crucified and slain." Here we read that God knew in advance that Christ would be slain. Was the death of Christ an accident? Absolutely not. The death of Christ was not an accident. Why did God foreknow it? Was it because God looked ahead in His divine crystal ball and saw that they would crucify His Son? No! He knew they would crucify Christ because God planned for Christ to die for the sins of the world. In fact, verse 23 clearly states, "Him, being delivered by the determinate counsel." You see, it was more than just looking ahead to see what would happen, it was the determinate council of God. In other words, God determined for this to happen and because God determined for it to happen, it says He foreknew it would happen. Here foreknowledge is determinative rather than informative.

The next occurrence of the word "foreknowledge" is used in a similar context in I Peter 1:18-20, "Forasmuch as ye know that ye were not redeemed with corruptible things, *as* silver and gold, from your vain conversation *received* by tradition from your fathers; But with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot: Who verily was fore-ordained...." Here the word translated "foreordained" is actually the Greek word for "foreknow." Continuing in verse 20, "Who verily was foreordained before the foundation of the world, but was manifest in these last times for you." Was the death of Christ foreknown because God looked ahead to see what would happen or because God planned for it to happen? It is very clear that God planned for Christ to shed His precious blood. Once again, in this text, foreknowledge is determinative, not informative.

The next area of divine foreknowledge spoken of in Scripture is foreknowledge of the nation of Israel. Paul writes, "I say then, Hath God cast away His people? God forbid. For I also am an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, *of* the tribe of Benjamin. God hath not cast away His people which He foreknew...." (Romans 11:1,2a). In what sense is Paul saying God foreknew His people Israel? Did God know Israel in advance because He looked ahead in a crystal ball and saw that they would be His chosen nation? No, He planned for Israel to be His chosen nation and knew in advance that He was going to establish them as special people. Just as Christ was foreknown as the One whom God would choose to die for sin, so the nation of Israel was known in advance to God as His chosen nation. Once more, His foreknowledge was determinative, not informative.

The next passage also has to do with God's foreknowledge of the nation Israel. I Peter 1:1-2 says, "Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, Elect according to the fore-knowledge of God the Father, through sanctification of the Spirit, unto obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ: Grace unto you, and peace, be multiplied." Here Peter tells his readers that they are "elect according to the foreknowledge of God." It is important to remember that election does not refer to God choosing someone to be saved. Election has to do with God choosing someone to a position (see chapter 6 on "election"). In the case of believers, God chooses that believers occupy a certain position. To whom is Peter referring in this letter? I Peter 2:9 tells us the answer, "But ye *are a* chosen generation, a royal

priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people." God is viewing these people as elect because they are a part of the special nation that He chose to use and if they are part of that nation, they are elect. In verse 2 of chapter 1, they are elect according to the foreknowledge of God. In other words, God foreknew the nation of Israel (which we saw in Romans 11). He knew in advance that they would be His special people because He determined to make them His special people. Israel was not elect because God looked ahead and saw that it would just happen that way. No, He foreknew they would be elect because He had determined to choose that nation. His foreknowledge was determinative, not informative.

One more use of the word "foreknow" is found in Scripture, and it is often used to attempt to prove that God looks ahead to see who will be saved and then predestinates them. Romans 8:29, "For whom He did foreknow, He also did predestinate." Now, if we were to stop there and ignore the context, it looks like an open and shut case of God looking ahead to see who will believe and then predestinating them. But, we need to look at the context and determine to whom is He referring. Let us first look at the rest of the verse and then back up and see what goes before it as well. "For whom He did foreknow, He also did predestinate *to be* conformed to the image of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren. Moreover whom He did predestinate, them He also called" (Rom. 8:29,30a). Now, at this point the Calvinist will say, "See, it says here whom He did predestinate, He called." And what they mean by "called" is, called to be saved. So they would argue that what Paul is saying here is that God foreknew, or determined who He would save, and then He predestinated that person, and then He called him. Is this what Paul is getting at here? Not at all!

Let us now step back and look at the broader context of the Book of Romans. The same word for "called" as we have in Romans 8:30, is also used in Romans 9:7, "Neither because they are the seed of Abraham are they all children but in Isaac shall thy seed be called." Here the Lord singles out, from the seed of Abraham in general, one individual through whom this nation would be called. The word "called" is being used here in the sense of being called by a certain name. Compare Romans 9:26, "And it shall come to pass, *that* in the place where it was said unto them, Ye *are* not my people; there shall they be called the children of the living God." Here, the idea that Paul is getting at when he says they are "called" is that they are going to be called by a certain name. More precisely, they are going to be called "children of the living God."

Now, with this in mind, let us go back to Romans 8:30. "Moreover whom He did predestinate, them He also called." What did He call them? Let us find out from previous statements in Romans. In Romans 1:7 Paul says, "To all that be in Rome, beloved of God, called *to be* saints." Now, you will notice the little words "to be" are in italics, which means they are not in the original text. What Paul literally said when he wrote this was "called saints." Are you a saint? Have you trusted Christ? If you are a believer in the Lord Jesus Christ, through faith in His finished work at Calvary, you can rightly be called a saint. Furthermore, right in chapter eight, the Holy Spirit calls us "children of God." "The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God" (Rom. 8:16). This is the name by which we

are called, and as such, we are called into God's service. This is the calling of Romans 8:30. The subject here is not how we came to be saved. Paul already covered that back in chapters 3-5. "Therefore being justified by faith" (Rom. 5:1). Remember what we have already seen with regard to predestination. What does predestination mean? What is its goal? It has to do with the final outcome for those who trust Christ. When we come to Romans chapter 8, Paul is now addressing those who have already trusted Christ.

When you trust Christ, you enter into a predetermined course which God has planned for all who believe. What is this course? It includes several things. This is what Paul is outlining in Romans 8:28-30. We know he is addressing believers, for he begins in verse 28, "And we know that all things work together for good to them that LOVE GOD, to them who are the called according to His purpose." What has God purposed for those who believe? He has determined in advance (foreknown) to do several things for those who become members of the Body of Christ by faith. He has purposed to predestinate them to the position of sonship (Eph. 1:5) and to be conformed to His image (Rom. 8:29). He has purposed to call them by His name, and into His service. He has purposed to justify those who believe, and also to glorify them (Rom. 8:30).

We have exhausted every occurrence of the word "foreknowledge" in the Bible, and none of them has anything to do with God picking some people to be saved. Foreknowledge is determinative, for it pertains to that which God planned to do with regard to sacrificing Christ, or what He planned to do for the Body of Christ (which He knew He would form). Which individuals would make up the Body of Christ is not the subject of "foreknowledge" as revealed in the Word of God.

PART THREE:
ANSWERS TO CALVINIST "PROOF-TEXTS"

Chapter Nine:

ROMANS CHAPTER 9

We, of course, believe we have answered many Calvinist "proof-texts" already in the previous chapters. In this section, we will review some of these points and bring up several more verses. The first passage we will cover has already been addressed, but deserves an entire chapter because of its importance to this subject. We are referring here to Romans chapter 9, which is considered the "stronghold" of Calvinist teaching.

The key to understanding Romans chapter 9 is to see it in its context (this is true of any portion of Scripture). Romans chapters 9, 10, and 11 make up the great dispensational section of this book. Here Paul deals with the question of how God could set aside the chosen nation Israel and turn to the Gentiles. As he writes, Paul, being a Jew after the flesh (Rom. 9:3), anticipates the questions and

objections that a Jewish person might have upon hearing that God is turning to the Gentiles. This is a common rhetorical devise which Paul uses throughout the Book of Romans. He raises a question and then answers it.

For example, a Jew might ask, "Paul, are you turning your back on your own countrymen?" To this the Apostle responds, "I say the truth in Christ, I lie not, my conscience also bearing me witness in the Holy Ghost, that I have great heaviness and continual sorrow in my heart. For I could wish that myself were accursed from Christ for my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh" (Rom. 9:1-3).

Another question might be, "But Paul, what about all the great promises made to us Israelites?" To this Paul responds, "Who are Israelites; to whom pertaineth the adoption, and the glory, and the covenants, and the giving of the law, and the service of God, and the promises; Whose are the fathers, and of whom as concerning the flesh Christ came, who is over all, God blessed for ever. Amen" (Rom. 9:4,5). Later in this dispensational section, Paul reminds them that God will indeed return to Israel and fulfill His promises to them (see Rom. 11:26,27).

A third question a Jew might raise upon hearing that God was turning to the Gentiles is, "Paul, are you forgetting that we are the seed of Abraham?" Paul's answer to this is, "Not as though the word of God hath taken none effect. For they are not all Israel, which are of Israel: Neither, because they are the seed of Abraham, are they all children: but, In Isaac shall thy seed be called" (Rom. 9:7).

A fourth question is, "How can God use Gentiles to serve Him when we Jews are God's chosen vessel?" Paul answers this in Romans 9:8-33. We will devote this chapter to Paul's answer to that question.

A fifth question Paul addresses is, "Does this mean God no longer has a desire to save Israelites?" The answer to this question is given in Romans chapter 10. Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved" (Rom. 10:1).

The final question Paul deals with in this section of Romans is, "Has Israel as a nation been set aside forever?" And the answer to this is found in Romans chapter 11. "I say then, Hath God cast away His people? God forbid" (Rom. 11:1a).

Calvinists often use several verses from Romans chapter 9 to support the notion that God picks some people to be saved and others are "hardened" so they will remain lost. In this chapter, we will show that this simply is not the case. We have already covered Romans 9:11-13, but will review it here so we see it in the context of the entire chapter. "For the children being not yet born, neither having done any good or evil, that the purpose of God according to election might stand, not of works, but of Him that calleth; It was said unto her, The elder shall serve the younger. As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated" (Rom. 9:11-13).

This remarkable passage is construed by Calvinism to mean that before Jacob and Esau were born, Jacob was chosen to be saved and Esau to be damned. The text says nothing of the sort. C.R. Stam correctly comments, "Surely the above passage has nothing to do with predestination to Heaven or Hell. It does not say, nor imply that God gave eternal life to Jacob but consigned Esau to eternal damnation, much less that God loved Jacob and hated Esau *before they were born.* Nor yet does 'the purpose of God according to election,' in verse 11, have to do with eternal salvation and reprobation, but rather with His purpose to make the descendants of Jacob, rather than those of Esau, His special people." [12]

It can easily be demonstrated that God had *nations,* not *individuals* in mind when He said to Rebekah, "The elder shall serve the younger." This quote comes from Genesis 25:23, "And the LORD said unto her, Two nations are in thy womb, and two manner of people shall be separated from thy bowels; and the one people shall be stronger than the other people; and the elder shall serve the younger." Furthermore, we know God had nations, not individuals in mind, for Esau never served Jacob personally. But the nation which descended from Esau (Edom) did serve the nation which descended from Jacob (Israel). An example of this is found in I Chronicles, "And he put garrisons in Edom; and all the Edomites became David's servants" (I Chron. 18:13a).

The statement, "Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated" (Rom. 9:13) is often used by Calvinists to "prove" that God picked Jacob to be saved and Esau to be lost, even before they were born. But the fact is, this statement was first made in Malachi 1:2, some FOURTEEN HUNDRED YEARS after they were born. Again, the point in Malachi is not God's love or hatred for Jacob and Esau, personally. Rather, it refers to God's view of the two nations which descended from these two men.

Now, what is the point of this discussion of Jacob and Esau? Remember the overall context of Romans chapters 9-11 is to explain how God could set aside the Jews and turn to the Gentiles. Paul is simply illustrating from history that God can work through whomever He chooses, and if He decides to depart from the "norm," He has the fight to do so. Technically, Esau should have become the chosen nation, because he was the firstborn. But God, in His sovereignty, chose to use Jacob instead to become the father of the chosen nation.

The next illustration of this comes from the example of Moses. Romans 9:15 says, "For He saith to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I will have compassion." Again, the Calvinist sees this as God choosing certain people to be saved. But the fact is, if we consult the passage from which Paul is quoting, we find that it is not dealing with salvation at all. Instead, the context (Exodus 33) is dealing with the question of whether God would continue to use Israel, or if He would make Moses a great nation. To understand why Paul quotes this passage, we need to go back and see what happened at that time.

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[12] *Commentary of Romans,* by C.R. Stam, p. 221.

The whole episode leading up to the "I will have mercy" statement began in Exodus chapter 32 with the golden calf incident. At that time, God was ready to destroy the whole lot and make a great nation out of Moses: "And the LORD said unto Moses, I have seen this people, and, behold, it is a stiffnecked people: Now therefore let me alone, that my wrath may wax hot against them, and that I may consume them: and I will make of thee a great nation" (Exod. 32:9, 10). The careful reader will take note that the context again is not one of personal salvation, but of national calling and service. Would God continue to use this stubborn nation? Moses, of course, intercedes for Israel, reminding God of His promises to the fathers, "Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, thy servants, to whom thou swarest by thine own self, and saidst unto them, I will multiply your seed as the stars of heaven, and all this land that I have spoken of will I give unto your seed, and they shall inherit it for ever" (Exod. 32:13). At this, God agrees not to destroy the nation, but issues a very somber warning.

At that point, the Lord informs Moses that Israel may continue the journey to the promised land, but that only an Angel would be sent with them, not the Lord Himself. "Therefore now go, lead the people unto the place of which I have spoken unto thee: behold, mine Angel shall go before thee: nevertheless in the day when I visit I will visit their sin upon them" (Exod. 32:34). God is telling Moses that the reason He cannot come personally into the camp is because if He did, His holy wrath would destroy the people. Therefore, God would send an angel instead. Moses is still not satisfied with this answer, so he goes outside the camp to meet once more with God (Exod. 33:7). There he pleads with God to still consider Israel to be His chosen nation, "Now therefore, I pray thee, if I have found grace in thy sight, shew me now thy way, that I may know thee, that I may find grace in thy sight: AND CONSIDER THAT THIS NATION IS THY PEOPLE" (Exod. 33:13).

To this God replies, "My presence shall go with thee, and I will give thee rest" (Exod. 33:14). Desiring confirmation of this, Moses asks to see God's glory (vs. 18), and it is at this point, God states, "I will make all my goodness pass before thee, and I will proclaim the name of the LORD before thee; and will be gracious to whom I will be gracious, and will shew mercy on whom I will shew mercy" (Exod. 33:19). The entire context has nothing to do with personal salvation, but has everything to do with God's choice of which nation to use in His service. This is precisely why Paul quotes this verse in Romans chapter 9, where he is addressing the same subject.

In Romans 9:16, Paul summarizes the basis on which God showed mercy to Israel by not destroying them and to Moses by showing him His glory: "So then it is not of him that willeth, nor of him that runneth, but of God that sheweth mercy." It was not human will power or exertion, but God' s own choice. This could also be applied to God's choice of Jacob over Esan as the progenitor of the chosen race. Jacob (and Rebekah) tried to exert their will upon Isaac to bless Jacob, and Esau ran to the field to hunt for savory venison. But through it all, it was God who overruled to insure that His choice prevailed to make Jacob (Israel) the chosen race. Again, we remind our reader that all of these contexts have nothing to do with personal salvation, but rather with God's choice of a special nation to serve Him.

The next example Paul calls upon is that of Pharaoh. "For the Scripture saith unto Pharaoh, Even for this same purpose have I raised thee up, that I might shew my power in thee, and that my name might be declared throughout the earth" (Rom. 9:17). The words "raised thee up" are often interpreted to mean that God brought Pharaoh into existence for the purpose stated in verse 17. But this is not the "raising up" Paul has in mind. In Exodus 9:16 (from which Paul is quoting), the Hebrew word for "raised" means "to cause to stand." This goes back to the sixth plague, where we read, "And the magicians could not stand before Moses because of the boils..." (Exod. 9:1 la). The word, "stand" in verse 11, and "raised" in verse 16 are the same word! In other words, God raised Pharaoh up from the plague of boils so that he could continue to resist Moses by not releasing the children of Israel.

Romans 9:18 continues, "Therefore hath He mercy on whom He will have mercy, and whom He will He hardeneth." Again, the Calvinist proclaims, "See, Pharaoh had no choice but to resist, for God hardened his hem!" Let us once more go back into the context of Exodus and see exactly what God did with Pharaoh. In this passage, three different Hebrew words are used which are all translated "harden" in English. One is the word, "qashah" which means to be cruel or stubborn. This word is used once of the hardening of Pharaoh's heart (Exod. 7:14). Previous to this, however, a different word is used; "chazaq," which means "to strengthen." This word is used the first time we read of God hardening Pharaoh's heart: "but I will harden his heart, that he shall not let the people go" (Exod. 4:21b). Pharaoh already had it in his heart not to let Israel go, "I am sure that the king of Egypt will not let you go, no, not by a mighty hand" (Exod. 3:19). When God says He will harden Pharaoh's heart, He is literally saying that He will "strengthen" the resolve Pharaoh already had in his heart. That is, God knew that the plagues would "soften" Pharaoh up, but He wanted his heart to remain hard so all ten plagues could fall on all the gods of Egypt. Each plague was directed at one of the Egyptian gods; therefore, the Lord wanted Pharaoh to remain hardened until all ten gods had been judged. "For the Egyptians buried all their firstborn, which the LORD had smitten among them: upon their gods also the LORD executed judgments" (Num. 33:4).

Again, the context is clear. God did not harden Pharaoh's heart so he would not be saved. God strengthened Pharaoh's resolve to hold Israel captive, so all ten gods of Egypt could be judged. God states that His purpose in all this was "that I might shew my power in thee, and that my name might be declared throughout all the earth" (Rom. 9:17b). Paul's whole point here is that God used a GENTILE KING to glorify Himself in the earth. It should not be surprising, then, that God would now use Gentiles to do His work.

The next example Paul uses to show that God can use Gentiles in His service is that of Cyrus the king of Persia. "Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus? Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honour, and another unto dishonour?" (Rom. 9:20,21). Here, Paul is

alluding to Isaiah 45:9, "Woe unto him that striveth with his Maker! Let the potsherd strive with the potsherds of the earth. Shall the clay say to Him that fashioneth it, What makest thou? or thy work, He hath no hands?" In this context, God is referring to the Gentile king, Cyrus, who was used of God to decree that the Jews could return to the Promised Land after their Babylonian captivity: "Thus saith the LORD to his anointed, to Cyrus, whose right hand I have holden..." (Isa. 45:1). The Lord knew that Israel might react to Cyrus being used to carry out God's purpose, therefore, he warns Israel in Isaiah 45:9, "Woe unto him that striveth with his Maker..."

As Paul writes, he anticipates the Jews' negative reaction to hearing that God was turning to the Gentiles. Therefore, he quotes from Isaiah to show that this was not the first time God used a Gentile to carry out His purpose. Once again, we remind our readers that the context from which Paul quotes in Isaiah is not one of personal salvation, but of God's choice of a vessel to use to carry out His purposes.

Before moving on to another illustration of how God may choose whomever He desires to be His servants, Paul makes an application of the things he has just discussed. "What if God, willing to shew His wrath, and to make His power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction: And that He might make known the riches of His glory on the vessels of mercy, which He had afore prepared unto glory, Even us, whom He hath called, not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles" (Rom. 9:22-24). Predestinarians interpret this verse to mean that God predetermines who will receive wrath/destruction and who will receive mercy/glory. This is not the point of this verse!

The point Paul is making is that it is God who determines what will become of those who receive wrath and what will become of those who receive mercy. It is as though God has established two "clubs": the "wrath club" and the "mercy club." The "benefits" of belonging to each club have already been predetermined by God, but the membership is open to whoever wants to join. This is illustrated in another "potter and clay" passage in the Old Testament. Jeremiah wrote by inspiration, "O house of Israel, cannot I do with you as this potter? saith the LORD. Behold, as the clay is in the potter's hand, so are ye in mine hand, O house of Israel. At what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to pluck up, and to pull down, and to destroy it; If that nation, against whom I have pronounced, turn from their evil, I will repent of the evil that I thought to do unto them" (Jer. 18:6,7). Notice that the nation in question is given the freedom to choose to turn from their evil, but what happens if they do not is already predetermined by God.

Likewise, God has predetermined that "vessels of wrath" will be "fitted for destruction" (Rom. 9:22). But praise be to God, members of the "wrath club" may join the "mercy club" by faith in the Lord Jesus Christ! They then become "vessels of mercy," which God has predetermined to be "prepared unto glory" (Rom. 9:23). Finally, Paul reminds the Jews that Jews AND Gentiles may be a part of the "mercy club." "Even us, whom He hath called, not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles" (Rom. 9:24).

Now, back to another illustration: In verse 25, Paul gives another example of how God may reject or restore a nation as He pleases. "As He saith also in Osee (Hosea), I will call them my people, which were not my people; and her beloved, which was not beloved" (Rom. 9:25). Paul is not referring to Gentiles here, as many suppose, but rather to Israel. "And it shall come to pass, that in the place where it was said unto them, Ye are not my people; there shall they be called the children of the living God" (Rom. 9:26). This is a quote of Hosea 1:10, "Yet the number of the children of Israel shall be as the sand of the sea, which cannot be measured nor numbered; and it shall come to pass, that in the place where it was said unto them, Ye are not my people, there it shall be said unto them, Ye are the sons of the living God." The context here is not personal salvation, but of national calling. This is precisely why Paul quotes it in Romans chapter 9.

A final illustration Paul chooses is from the book of Isaiah. "Esaias also crieth concerning Israel, Though the number of the children of Israel be as the sand of the sea, a remnant shall be saved" (Rom. 9:27). The remnant here refers to the true believers in Israel. Again, Paul's point is clear, especially to the Jew in his audience. Just being part of the Chosen Nation did not save them spiritually. What did they need? "But Israel, which followed after the law of righteousness, hath not attained to the law of righteousness. Wherefore? Because they sought it not by faith..." (Rom. 9:31,32a). They needed FAITH! As Brother C.R. Stam so aptly puts it, "Mark well, the Apostle does not say that they had failed to obtain righteousness because God had not elected them to salvation, but because they had sought to gain it by works rather than by faith. This is important, appearing as it does, at the close of such a chapter as Romans 9." [13]

In verse 30, Paul "rubs it in" just a little by reminding the Jew "That the Gentiles, which followed not after righteousness, have attained to righteousness, even the righteousness which is of faith" (Rom. 9:30). The words, "have attained" literally mean "to take eagerly" or to "seize." When offered salvation by grace through faith, many indeed eagerly seize upon the opportunity and believe!

Far from teaching that only some are "elect" to salvation, Romans chapter 9 clearly shows that anyone can be saved by faith, and "whosoever believeth on Him shall not be ashamed" (Rom. 9:33; cf. Rom. 10:11).

Chapter Ten:

OTHER "PROOF-TEXTS"

We have placed the term "proof-texts" in quotes because many passages used to "prove" a teaching often do not, when considered in their context. Such, we believe, is the case with many Calvinist "proof-texts." While ardent Calvinists tend to find "support" for their views on predestination, etc. in almost every part of Scripture, we will limit ourselves to some of the most commonly used (or misused) texts.

[13] Stam, Op. cit. p. 235.

Jeremiah 1:5

"Before I formed thee in the belly I knew thee; and before thou camest forth out of the womb I sanctified thee, and I ordained thee a prophet unto the nations." This verse says nothing about choosing Jeremiah for salvation. Indeed, it clearly shows the point we have contended all along, that election is to a position of service. In the case of Jeremiah, it was to be "a prophet unto the nations." Jeremiah was "sanctified," or "set apart" to this ministry before he was born.

Matthew 22:14

"For many are called, but few are chosen." Calvinists make much of the distinction between the words, "called" (Gk. kletos) and "chosen" (Gk. eklektos). They would suggest that God calls many, but only the elect believe. This is not the point at all. The meaning here is that God calls many, but only chooses for His service those who do respond in faith. But why does it say "many" are called instead of "all" are called? It is because the context here is Israel. God called many (the Jews) to be His servants, but only those who believed could be chosen to that position.

John 1:13

"Which were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God." This statement is usually taken to refer back to those who became sons of God in verse 12. Calvinists teach that becoming a son of God has nothing to do with the will of man. But actually, it refers back to Christ. John 1:12 literally reads, "But as many as received Him, He gave to them authority children of God to be, to those that believe on His name"[14] (we realize this sounds awkward, but this is the literal word order in the Greek). The pronoun, "His," referring to Christ, is in the genetive case, which makes it possessive. Thus, the end of verse 12 could be translated, "to those that believe on the name of Him...." Then, verse 13 continues, in the Greek text, "who not of bloods" (the word "blood" is plural in the Greek text). That is, Christ was not born through the mixing of "bloods" (a man and a woman's blood), but He was born of a virgin. The next phrase says, "nor of the will of the flesh." Again, it was not through a fleshly relationship that Mary gave birth to Jesus (as some supposed). "Nor of (the) will of man," that is, it was not through Joseph's decision that the Christ child was born. How did it happen then? It was "of God." That is, Jesus was begotten of the Holy Spirit. Verse 13 ends with the words "were born," which is why the verse is usually applied to the sons of God rather than to Christ. But E.W. Bullinger points to manuscript authority which puts it in the singular ("was born"), which would confirm that it is referring to Christ.[15]

John 6:44

"No man can come to me, except the Father which hath sent me draw him: and I will raise Him up at the last day." This statement must be taken in the context of

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[14] *The Englishman's Greek New Testament,* pub. by Zondervan, pp. 241,242.
[15] *The Companion Bible,* edited by E.W. Bullinger, note on John 1:13.

what God was doing in Israel at that time. God the Father had taught Israel through the prophets, that Christ would come. At least some Israelites believed this with all their heart and were waiting for the Messiah. An example of this is Simeon: "And, behold, there was a man in Jerusalem, whose name was Simeon; and the same man was just and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel: and the Holy Ghost was upon him. And it was revealed unto him by the Holy Ghost, that he should not see death, before he had seen the Lord's Christ" (Luke 2:25,26). Simeon was a man who had truly been taught by the Father, through the prophets. "It is written in the prophets, And they shall be all taught of God. Every man therefore that hath heard, and hath learned of the Father, cometh unto me" (John 6:45). The ones which the Father drew to Christ were those who had already believed the testimony of the prophets and, therefore, received Christ as the Messiah when He finally appeared.

Indeed, the same principle applies to mankind today, though we are in a different dispensation. The only people who trust Christ, are those who respond in faith to the Word of God. "So then, faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God" (Rom. 10:17).

John 6:65

"And he said, Therefore said I unto you, that no man can come unto me, except it were given unto him of my Father." This verse continues the context we have just seen. The only ones who could come to Christ were those who had already believed what the prophets taught concerning Him. To these, God the Father gave further light to understand and believe on Christ. The key here is to understand the principle of progressive revelation. Those Israelites who had previously believed what God had said through the prophets were now eligible to believe on Christ. This is why Christ pointed the skeptics of His day back to the prophets. "Search the scriptures; for in them ye think ye have eternal life: and they are they which testify of me. And ye will not come to me that ye might have life" (John 5:39,40). The Jews did search the Scriptures, and concluded that they obtained life in simply knowing these writings. But Christ points out that the writings (Scriptures) were not an end in themselves, but rather, a way of revealing Christ who is the source of life.

John 12:39,40

"Therefore they could not believe, because that Esaias said again, He hath blinded their eyes, and hardened their heart; that they should not see with their eyes, nor understand with their heart and be converted, and I should heal them." Dual electionists see this as a positive statement that certain people cannot believe, because they are not chosen. Therefore, in their view, they are chosen to be damned. Again, this is simply not the teaching of this context. Two things must be kept in mind.

First, Isaiah's prophecy refers to a national blinding of Israel, not to an inability of individuals in the nation to believe. This is demonstrated by John's comment immediately following his quote from Isaiah, "Nevertheless among the chief rulers

also many believed on him..." (John 12:42). That this refers to a national blindness of Israel is also proven by Paul's use of the same text (Isaiah chapter 6) when he addresses the Jews in Acts 28:25-27. Here, Paul is pointing out that "the salvation of God is sent unto the Gentiles" (Acts 28:28) as opposed to being wrought through the nation Israel.

A second thing to remember when John says, "they could not believe" (John 12:39), is that under the Kingdom program, people could come to a point of rejection where they would no longer be able to believe or repent. "For it is impossible for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost, And have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come, If they shall fall away, to renew them unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put Him to an open shame" (Heb. 6:4-6). Remember, this is stated in the Book of HEBREWS. There is no teaching in Paul's Epistles that a person can come to a place where they cannot believe!

John 15:16

"Ye have not chosen me, but I have chosen you, and ordained you, that ye should go and bring forth fruit, and that your fruit should remain: that whatsoever ye shall ask of the Father in my name, He may give it you." This passage is often employed to show that only the "chosen" can be saved. We remind our readers that Christ is addressing His twelve apostles (this is the upper room discourse) and is referring not to their salvation but to their calling as apostles. See chapter 6 and the section on "The Election of the Twelve Apostles" for more information on this subject.

Acts 2:47

"Praising God, and having favour with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily such as should be saved." While we hold the King James Version in high regard, the rendering of the end of this verse is unfortunate at best. Calvinists, looking for predestination at every turn, can easily take the words, "such as should be saved" to mean "those who are elect, but not yet saved." The literal rendering clears this up, for it reads, "and the Lord added those who were being saved daily...."

Acts 5:31 & Acts 11:18

"Him hath God exalted with His right hand to be a Prince and a Saviour, for to give repentance to Israel, and forgiveness of sins." "When they heard these things, they held their peace, and glorified God, saying, Then hath God also to the Gentiles granted repentance unto life." We quote these two verses together, because they present the same principle. When it speaks of "giving" repentance to Israel and to the Gentiles, it is not referring to a supernatural endowment of repentance to individuals. Rather, it refers to God's offer of repentance to the nation of Israel, and later to the Gentiles. Clearly, not every Israelite responded by repenting, any more than all Gentiles have. But the offer was extended to both.

Acts 13:48

"And when the Gentiles heard this, they were glad, and glorified the word of the Lord: and as many as were ordained to eternal life believed." Many Calvinists see this verse as the last word on predestination and final proof of their position: "as many as were ordained to eternal life believed." And indeed, without examining the grammar and the context, it looks like a watertight case. Those who were already ordained to be saved, believed. But is this the sense of what Luke is saying as he writes? Two major points must be considered.

The first of these is the grammar. By comparing Scripture with Scripture, we can gain a clearer understanding of the word, "ordained." The Calvinist automatically takes this word to mean "preordained" or "foreordained." But the same word is used in I Corinthians 16:15, where Paul writes, "I beseech you, brethren, (ye know the house of Stephanas, that it is the first-fruits of Achaia, and that they have addicted themselves to the ministry of the saints)." Here the word "addicted" is the same as the word translated "ordained" in Acts 13:48. When these Gentiles heard the gospel, they were "addicted" to it and, therefore, they believed it.

A second consideration here is the context. Two verses back, Luke records, "Then Paul and Barnabas waxed bold, and said, It was necessary that the word of God should first have been spoken to you: but seeing ye put it from you, and judge yourselves unworthy of everlasting life, lo, we turn to the Gentiles." Note carefully that these Jews which Paul addresses were responsible for their own predicament: "seeing YE PUT IT FROM YOU, and JUDGE YOURSELVES UNWORTHY of everlasting life." They made their own choice to reject the Word of God, but the Gentiles, on the other hand, were "addicted" to it.

Acts 16:14

"And a certain woman named Lydia, a seller of purple, of the city of Thyatira, which worshipped God, heard us: whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul." This is not a case of God reaching down and picking out a certain person and causing them to believe. Notice that the text says that she already "worshipped God." This simply illustrates the principle that when an individual responds positively to the light they have, God will give them more light. And indeed, it is God who opens the heart when He sees a person already responding to Him. Remember, "faith cometh by hearing and hearing by the word of God" (Rom. 10:17). When Paul spoke the Word of God to Lydia, God opened her already tender heart to believe it.

Romans 8:29,30

"For whom He did foreknow, He also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren. Moreover whom He did predestinate, them He also called: and whom He called, them He also justified: and whom He justified, them He also glorified." The Calvinist sees a

divine order here of "foreknown" - "pre-destinated" - "called" - "justified" - "glorified." And indeed, this is the order of THESE VERSES. But once again, the context must be taken into account. The previous verse begins this whole progression with the words, "And we know that all things work together for good to them THAT LOVE GOD, to them who are the called according to His purpose" (Rom. 8:28 - emphasis ours). If one is going to insist that the order of this progression be maintained, then you must begin in verse 28 with "them THAT LOVE GOD."

Furthermore, remember that being called has to do with our calling to service, not to salvation (see chapter six on "Election"). When someone comes to "love God" through faith in the Lord Jesus Christ, this sets him or her on a preordained path which God has already set forth. God has already "foreknown" what He will do for those who believe. He has already decided to predestinate them to the image of His son, call them into His service, justify them and ultimately glorify them. The whole point here, in the context of Romans 8:28, is that for those who "love God," everything will ultimately work out okay, because God has predetermined this course for anyone who will believe. This does not mean God has plotted every detail of the believer's life in advance, only these major points. Within the framework of these boundaries of being predestined to Christ's image, called into His service, justified and glorified, the Christian has great liberty to serve God in a variety of ways!

Romans Chapter 9

(See chapter 9 of this book for detailed exposition)

Romans 11:2a

"God hath not cast away His people which He foreknew." In what sense did God foreknow Israel? As a nation chosen to be His servants in the earth. Does this mean that every last Israelite would ultimately be saved? Of course not, but they were still chosen as a nation.

Romans 11:4

"But what saith the answer of God unto him? I have reserved to myself seven thousand men, who have not bowed the knee to the image of Baal." While some may see this as God's choice to save seven thousand men, this is not the meaning of the context from which Paul quotes. This passage comes from I Kings 19:17,18 - "And it shall come to pass, that him that escapeth the sword of Hazael shall Jehu slay: and him that escapeth from the sword of Jehu shall Elisha slay. Yet I have left me seven thousand in Israel, all the knees which have not bowed unto Baal, and every mouth which hath not kissed him." This prediction by God simply indicates that in the coming turmoil, God would preserve seven thousand men from being killed. Why were these seven thousand to be spared? It is because they "have not bowed unto Baal." This was the faithful remnant of believers to whom God would offer special protection. It is not a case of God picking some to be saved (spiritually), but rather, God's protection for those who had already believed.

Romans 11:5

"Even so then at this present time also there is a remnant according to the election of grace." Following on the heels of verse 4, Paul affirms that even now, there is a remnant of believers among the Jewish people. But now it is not according to God's election of Israel, rather, it is under the auspices of the "election of grace"; that is, Jews (or anyone for that matter) who believe today are not part of a chosen nation, but rather, they become part of a chosen Body, the Body of Christ. It is the Church, the Body of Christ that God has chosen to serve Him in this Dispensation of Grace. Therefore, anyone who believes today becomes a part of the "election of grace."

Galatians 2:15

"But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother's womb, and called me by His grace." This is similar to Jeremiah's calling to be a prophet, even before he was born. But in this case, it is Paul being called to be the apostle of the Gentiles. The context continues, "and called me by His grace, to reveal His Son in me, that I might preach Him among the heathen" (Gal. 2:15b, 16a). The calling here is not to salvation, but to a special place of service.

Ephesians 1:4

"According as He hath chosen us in Him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before Him in love." Remember, this verse does not say, "according as He hath chosen us before the foundation of the world." This, of course, leaves out the two words that give us the key to the verse: "IN HIM." We most assuredly are NOT chosen in and of ourselves. This verse does not say that God picks out some people to be saved. It states that "the saints" and "the faithful (or those full of faith) in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 1:1) are chosen "IN HIM"; that is, Christ is already the elect of God (Isa. 42:1), and those who believe on Him also become part of the elect Body of Christ. And what is the goal of this calling, or election? "That we should be holy and without blame before Him" (Eph. 1:4b).

Ephesians 1:11

"In whom also we have obtained an inheritance, being predestinated according to the purpose of Him who worketh all things after the counsel of His own will." Again, this verse does not say anyone is predestinated to be saved. Rather, it says that the saints (those already saved) are predestinated to receive an inheritance. How does one fall into this blessed category? The next verse tells us: "That we should be to the praise of His glory, WHO FIRST TRUSTED IN CHRIST" (Eph. 1:12, emphasis ours). Before you get in on the wonderful, predestinated plan God has for all saints, you FIRST must TRUST IN CHRIST! What could be clearer?

Ephesians 2:8,9

"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast." This wonderful and familiar passage is often used by Calvinists to show that even your personal faith in Christ is something given to you, and not something you exercised yourself. This teaching is based on the words, "through faith; and that not of yourselves." They claim the word "that" modifies and describes "faith," therefore, faith is something given to the believer, not something he himself exercised. But this is simply not supported by the grammar of the text. Commenting on this, Roger T. Forster explains, "The words *faith* and *grace* are both feminine in gender, but the word *that* is neuter. If the latter had been intended as a simple reference back either to faith or to grace, Paul would certainly not have used the neuter form *(touto)* but the feminine form *(houte)* which is quite different. The best interpretation that the Greek would seem to allow is for the phrase in verse 8, 'for by grace have you been saved through faith,' to be regarded as a similar type of parenthesis to that in verse 5: 'by grace have you been saved' - which many versions put in brackets. This would imply that the word *that* refers back to the whole process described in verses 4-7 of God quickening us and raising us together with Christ to show His grace to us in the heavenly places. None of this, Paul says, is through works, but is a gift of God."[16]

I Thessalonians 5:9; II Thessalonians 2:13

"For God hath not appointed us to wrath, but to obtain salvation by our Lord Jesus Christ." "But we are bound to give thanks alway to God for you, brethren beloved of the Lord, because God hath from the beginning chosen you to salvation through sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the troth." It is a well-known fact that the word "salvation" does not always refer to spiritual salvation, but to a physical deliverance of some sort. When Paul wrote to the Philippians, "For I know that this shall turn to my salvation through your prayer..." (Phil. 1:19), he did not mean their prayers would save him spiritually. He meant that he was confident that their prayers would have an effect on his deliverance from prison.

The context must always determine whether the writer is speaking of physical or spiritual salvation. In both of the Thessalonian passages quoted above, Paul has just been discussing the tribulation period. In I Thessalonians 5, Paul speaks of "the day of the Lord" and the "sudden destruction" that will befall the lost. But God has not appointed "the children of the day" (believers) to these things, but rather, he has appointed us to be delivered from these things. Likewise, in II Thessalonians 2, Paul has been discussing "that Wicked" one and the "strong delusion" which will come upon the lost in the tribulation. But God has chosen us to salvation *from these things* through "sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth." That is, the Holy Spirit will sanctify, or set us apart from these things, and it is effected in the individual by "belief of the truth." How did God call us into this special position and privilege? The next verse tells us, "Whereunto He called you by our gospel" (II Thess. 2:14a).

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[16] Roger T. Forster & V. Paul Marston, *God's Strategy in Human History,* p. 268.

This whole process can be summarized thus: God extends a call to mankind through the gospel. Those who believe become members of the Body of Christ. God has already determined to set the Body of Christ apart and deliver them from the tribulation. When a person believes the truth of the gospel, he or she then receives this benefit which God already planned to provide for the Body of Christ.

I Timothy 2:4

"(God), Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth." While this verse is often used by Universal Reconciliationists (U.R.) to prove that all mankind will eventually be saved, Calvinists sometimes employ this passage to show that people are saved because God "wills" it to be so. The solution to these misinterpretations by both U.R. and Calvinism is in the word "will." In this text, Paul does not use the stronger word for God's will (boulomal), but rather, uses the word, "thelo" (here in the plural) which means God's desirous will. That is, God desires that all men be saved and come to the knowledge of the truth. But though He desires this, He does not force it upon anyone.

I Peter 1:2

"Elect according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, through sanctification of the Spirit, unto obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ: Grace unto you, and peace, be multiplied." We have already covered this passage under the headings of "Election" and "Foreknowledge," but we remind our readers now of a few facts. First, Peter is addressing Israel as a nation in this letter. Verse 1 says, "Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia." Many assume Peter is addressing Gentiles, because of the translation of the word "strangers" and because of the names of the countries listed. But the truth is, the word "strangers" comes from the word "diaspora," which refers to the Jews of the dispersion. The reason they are in these various countries is because they were dispersed from Israel.

Furthermore, Peter clearly identifies these people as members of the nation of Israel in the next chapter: "But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an HOLY NATION..." (I Pet. 2:9). This is a direct reference back to Exodus 19:6, "And ye shall be unto me a kingdom of priests, and an HOLY NATION. These are the words which thou shalt speak unto the CHILDREN OF ISRAEL" (emphasis ours). Peter is simply identifying his readers as part of the elect nation which God chose according to His foreknowledge.

II Peter 3:9

"The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance." The first thing to note in this verse is that Peter flatly denies the Calvinist doctrine of dual election, or the election of the lost to damnation. He writes, "not willing that any should perish." Incidently, Peter uses the stronger word here for God's will, "boulomai." That is, Peter is NOT simply saying that God does

not desire that any should perish. This, of course, would also be true, for God does not desire people to perish. But Peter, by divine inspiration, chooses the stronger word, therefore, showing that God is not DETERMINING that any should perish.

But this leaves us with an apparent quandary in the last part of the verse, "...but that all should come to repentance." If the strong word for God's will applies to the first clause which states that "God is not willing anyone to perish," then the same word must apply to the second clause, "but that all should come to repentance." Of course, this suits the Universal Reconciliationist just fine, for U.R. teaches that someday, all will come to repentance. The solution to this is actually quite simple, and lies in the word "come." The negative form of this word is found in Mark 2:2, where we read, "And straightway many were gathered together, insomuch that there was NO ROOM to receive them...." The root word, translated "come" in II Peter 3:9 literally means "to make room for." And this, of course, agrees with the rest of the testimony of Scripture. God is not determining that any perish, but He IS determining that all "have room for" repentance. This does not mean that everyone will repent, but it means that God has willed that it is possible for all mankind to repent.

Revelation 17:8

"The beast that thou sawest was, and is not; and shall ascend out of the bottomless pit, and go into perdition: and they that dwell on the earth shall wonder, whose names were not written in the book of life from the foundation of the world, when they behold the beast that was, and is not, and yet is." The author believes the "book of life" to be exclusively Jewish (Paul's only reference to it is in the context of "circumcision" believers - cp. Phil. 4:3 with Col. 4:11). But even if it applies to believers of every dispensation, notice what it DOES and DOES NOT say. Revelation 17:8 does NOT say that anyone's names were written in the book of life from the foundation of the world, only that these people were not. In fact, nowhere does the Bible say that anyone's name was written in the book of life from the foundation of the world. People's names were added to the book of life when they believed. Here in Revelation chapter 17, the angel is simply telling John that at no time since the foundation of the world, were the names of these people added to the book of life. In other words, they are unbelievers.

CHAPTER ELEVEN:

PRACTICAL RAMIFICATIONS

We shall now consider the practical side of election and predestination. It is unfortunate but true that many people harbor the notion that doctrine is not very practical. Actually, the opposite is true. As we search and meditate upon the Scriptures, we will find that God has a very practical insight for us when He gives us the doctrines of the Bible. Why, then, do so many people find doctrine impractical? The answer is very simple. Much of the doctrine that people find impractical is false doctrine to begin with. Take our subject of election and predestination. According to the traditional view that some are chosen to be saved

and others are not, it is easy to see why such a doctrine would be viewed as impractical. If this doctrine were true, it would mean that no matter what we do or say as we witness to people, it would not, nor could it have any effect on the outcome. What could be more impractical?

But, praise God, this is not the testimony of Scripture! For example, Paul urges the believing husband or wife to remain with the unbelieving spouse, "For what knowest thou, O wife, whether thou shalt save thy husband? or how knowest thou, O man, whether thou shalt save thy wife?" (I Cor. 7:16). Does he mean that the believing husband or wife can provide forgiveness of sin for their spouse? Of course not! Only Christ can do that. But the human responsibility is so great that the believer who remains with an unbelieving spouse as a gentle testimony to the gospel can actually "save" the unsaved husband or wife. Our words and deeds really can make a difference as to whether a person becomes saved! Paul illustrates this another way in I Corinthians 9:22, "To the weak became I as weak, that I might gain the weak: I am made all things to all men, that I might by all means SAVE SOME." Now that is practical doctrine!

Election is actually a very practical doctrine when understood properly. As we have shown in previous chapters, our election has to do with God's call to service to all who believe. This becomes very practical to us when we realize that God has placed us in this position for a purpose. Our lives have tree purpose. When we look at the world around us, we see many people wandering around with no purpose in life. They are merely getting by, just existing, and for what purpose? It is no wonder that they simply cannot handle it. But, when we understand election means that God has placed us in a position of ministry and a place of blessing with tree purpose in life, it becomes extremely practical to our everyday living.

Let us examine several practical ramifications of our study of election and predestination and show how it affects our everyday life. The first ramification is that all men are truly save-able. Every last person on the face of the earth COULD be saved. "And He (Jesus Christ) is the propitiation for our sins: and not for our's only, but also for *the sins of* the whole world" (I John 2:2). This is what makes the gospel the "good news" that it is. Christ has already paid the price of mankind's sin. All they need to do is BELIEVE!

A second practical ramification of election and predestination is that God is in control. This is what we mean by the "sovereignty of God." Sovereignty literally means to rule over all. The traditional view of sovereignty is that in eternity past, God made a plan down to every last detail of life and that nothing whatsoever can alter that plan. This is the view of the Islamic religion. They believe in a "fatalistic" view of life in which everything that happens was "Allah's will." If something goes right, it is Allah's will. If something goes wrong, it is Allah's will, down to every last detail.

This is not the teaching of Scripture. The Bible teaches that God has an overall plan, but that He has allowed for some of the details to literally go either way. Of course, He knows all the options, and what would happen if "this choice," or "that

choice" were made. But God truly allows real choices in our lives. To some, this freedom of choice seems to make God less sovereign, but actually, the opposite is true. Let me illustrate.

What do we mean when we say that God is sovereign, and that He rules over all? In Daniel chapter 2 we read about the dream that Nebuchadnezzar had of the great image with the head of gold, arms and breast of silver, belly of bronze, and thighs and legs and feet of iron. What was the meaning of this? Daniel interprets this for the king: "Thou, O king, *art* a king of kings: for the God of heaven hath given thee a kingdom, power, and strength, and glory. And wheresoever the children of men dwell, the beasts of the field and the fowls of the heaven hath He given into thine hand, and hath made thee ruler over them all." Here is the definition of sovereignty, "ruler over them all." Then, as you work your way down the image, you start with the most sovereign kind of rulership or leadership, and by the time you get down to the feet of clay mixed with iron, you have the least sovereignty. Why? Because the feet of iron and clay represents the ten-nation league where no single king has any sovereignty at all. Nebuchadnezzar, represented by the head of gold, had more sovereignty than any king or ruler that followed after him.

What was Nebuchadnezzar's sovereignty like? In Daniel 5:18-19, Daniel speaks to Belshazzar, a descendant of Nebuchadnezzar and says, "O thou king, the most high God gave Nebuchadnezzar thy father a kingdom, and majesty, and glory, and honour: And for the majesty that He gave him, all people, nations, and languages, trembled and feared before Him: whom He would He slew; and whom He would He kept alive; and whom He would He set up; and whom He would He put down." Now that is a lot of sovereignty!

The next level down on the image was the arms and the breast of silver. What kingdom does this represent? It is the kingdom of the Medes and Persians. What kind of sovereignty did the king of the Medes and the Persians have? We find out in Daniel chapter 6. Here, Daniel's enemies drafted a law passed which stated that no one could pray to anyone except to the king. Then they took it to king Darius and said, "Now, O king, establish the decree, and sign the writing, that it be not changed, according to the law of the Medes and Persians, which altereth not." Daniel, of course, broke this law by praying to the true God. King Darius was sorry to hear this, and tried to save Daniel: "Then the king, when he heard *these* words, was sore displeased with himself, and set *his* heart on Daniel to deliver him: and he laboured till the going down of the sun to deliver him." Of course, he could not, for he was bound by the law of the Medes and the Persians "which altereth not." Now, at this point we ask, who had more sovereignty: Nebuchadnezzar or Darius? The answer is, Nebuchadnezzar.

The sovereignty of Calvinism is the sovereignty of Darius and the law of the Medes and the Persians. Calvinism has God locked into a fixed plan where every last detail is predetermined and nothing can change it. But the Scripture teaches that God has an even greater sovereignty than that. Yes, God has spoken certain things in prophecy that He has determined to bring to pass, and He will not change

course. He will bring about the Rapture, He will bring the Tribulation period, He will establish the Kingdom, He will do all these things, of course. But within the framework of how God has established the universe, He has left Himself the freedom to do whatever He wants! As long as it is in accordance with His character and overall purposes, He has reserved the right to give genuine freedom of choice to mankind, for He desires that we love and serve Him freely! This is what real, Biblical sovereignty is all about.

This also means that Romans 8:28 is really true! "And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to *His* purpose." Have you really thought about this verse? Notice that it does not say all things are good, does it? A lot of bad things happen in this world. Now, if God is the author of absolutely everything that happens, we have a problem, because there is a lot of sin in the world which is caused by Satan, the world system and our fallen human race. Yet, God in His sovereignty can take even the evil which happens (which He never desired to take place), and He can use it in our lives for good so that we come away more like the image of Christ. And remember, this is the whole purpose of predestination. God has determined in advance that those who believe on Christ will be conformed to the image of Christ. Sovereignty means that God can take any situation, even though He did not cause it or plan it, and turn it to good.

A third very practical ramification of our study is that prayer can and does make a difference. The traditional view of God's sovereignty and predestination says that everything is going to turn out a certain way whether we pray or not. James, writing to the twelve tribes states, "The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much" (James 5:16b). Granted, this passage has a specific application to believers of God's Kingdom program for Israel. But it illustrates the point that prayer really can have an effect on the outcome of a situation. Verse 17 continues, "Elias was a man subject to like passions as we are and he prayed earnestly that it might not rain and it rained not on the earth by the space of three years and six months and he prayed again and the heaven gave rain and the earth brought forth her fruit."

Did Paul believe that prayer could alter the outcome of a situation? Yes he did. Paul wrote in Philippians 1:19, "For I know that this shall turn to my salvation through your prayer." The context here is not spiritual salvation, but a physical deliverance from prison. Paul really believed that the Philippian believers' prayers would make a difference.

A fourth ramification of our study of election and predestination is that God does have a plan for our lives, but He will not force it upon us. Remember, the purpose of election is to place those who believe in a position of blessing and responsibility. In II Corinthians 5:20 Paul states, "Now then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech *you* by us: we pray *you* in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God." What is our position as members of the Body of Christ, and to what has God chosen us? We are chosen as ambassadors for Christ. What else does God have planned for us? Ephesians 2:8-10, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: *it is* the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should

boast. For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works." Now, notice that these are good works, "which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them." God has ordained certain things for believers to do which He calls "good works." Does this mean believers always do good works? No, but God has ordained that we "should" do them.

Man truly can make choices. One of the main passages of Scripture which shows this is Deuteronomy 30:19 where Moses has just enumerated all the blessings and the curses which are set before Israel. Then he says, "I call heaven and earth to record this day against you, *that* I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing: therefore choose life that both thou and thy seed may live." Why would God say this if it really were not possible to make a choice?

This freedom to choose, however, is always designed to be used to serve God, not sin. I Corinthians 8:9 states, "But take heed lest by any means this liberty (this freedom) of your's become a stumblingblock to them that are weak." And Galatians 5:13 says, "For, brethren, ye have been called unto liberty; only *use* not liberty for an occasion to the flesh, but by love serve one another." Do we have freedom? Yes we do. Should we use this freedom to commit sin? No, of course not! God gave us freedom to serve one another, and to love and serve Him. Let us use this freedom wisely!

A fifth ramification is that as long as God's Word is not violated, there may be more than one way to accomplish something. There may be more than one legitimate choice, in a godly sense, as to how we do something, or what we do. A good example of this is marriage. How many times have we heard the expression, "That marriage was made in Heaven?" Well, as one brother has said, "so is thunder and lightning!" We even knew a dear lady in a former congregation who told us, "It says in the Bible that marriages are made in Heaven." When we responded that this quote is not from Scripture, she got her Bible and searched and searched. Of course, it was not there.

What the Bible DOES teach is that a believer has freedom in choosing a mate, so long as it is within the parameters which God has established. In 1 Corinthians 7:39, Paul addresses the right of a widow to remarry: "The wife is bound by the law as long as her husband liveth; but if her husband be dead, she is at liberty to be married to whom she will; only in the Lord." Notice that Paul includes two qualifying phrases. First, she may be married "to whom she will." She is free to be married to anyone she desires, so long as her choice meets the second criterion, "only in the Lord." In other words, her choice must be a man who is a fellow believer. And right along with this, we would point out that a Grace Believer should hold the standard of only marrying another Grace Believer, for how "can two walk together, except they be agreed?" (Amos 3:3). Within these parameters, however, God gives the freedom to marry "whom she will."

The sixth practical ramification is that Christ will prevail in the end. I Corinthians 15:24-28 says, "Then *cometh* the end, when he shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father; when He shall have put down all rule and all

authority and power. For He must reign, till He hath all enemies under His feet. The last enemy *that* shall be destroyed *is* death. For He hath put all things under His feet. But when He saith all things are put under *Him, it is* manifest that He is excepted, which did put all things under Him. And when all things shall be subdued unto Him, then shall the Son also Himself be subject unto Him that put all things under Him, that God may be all in all." We are on the winning team! How is this aspect of predestination practical to us? Many people, even Christians, are very discouraged by what is happening in our land and in our world today. Yet, according to Scripture, we are on the winning team. God will prevail, and Christ will put all enemies down, even Satan, who has already been defeated judicially at the cross. This fact ought to give us great encouragement!

A seventh ramification, is that our goals for life are clearly defined in Scripture by God's ultimate goal for us. Romans 8:28,29: "And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to *His* purpose. For whom He did foreknow, He also did predestinate *to be* conformed to the image of His Son." This is what predestination is all about: being conformed to the image of His Son. This ought to establish for us the course of our life, for if we are to ultimately be conformed to the image of His Son, then we should begin heading towards that goal now. Understanding our final outcome should affect our daily walk. This is the reason why God gives us these great and profound doctrinal truths. He wants us to see where we are headed so that we might steer our course in that direction.

By God's grace, it is our prayer that this study will become to the reader much more than a mental exercise on a controversial subject. Rather, let us reevaluate our view of the lost. The unsaved really are saveable, every last one. It really is our responsibility to preach the gospel unto them, for "how shall they hear without a preacher?" (Rom. 10:14b). Our words, prayers and actions really do make a difference. Let us, by the power of the Holy Spirit and direction of the Word of God, live in a manner which is consistent with our high calling as "children of God!"